



Commemoration of the 125th Birth Anniversary of
Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee

An educationist, thinker and true nationalist who
stood for the unity & sovereignty of India

“Dr. Mookerjee’s sacrifice remains etched in our collective
memory. We reaffirm our commitment to building a
strong and developed India, guided by the values he
cherished and served till his last breath.”

- **Narendra Modi**
Prime Minister



Chief Guest

Shri Amit Shah

Hon’ble Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation

Date: Monday, 6th July, 2026 | Time: 5:00 pm onwards
Venue: Milan Mela Prangan (Hall B), Kolkata

Program Highlights

‘Melody, Culture & Nation’:
A musical tribute by CCRT to
Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee

A visual showcase of
125 feet statue of
Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee

Special exhibition with archival
material on the life of
Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee

In August Presence

Shri Suvendu Adhikari
Hon’ble Chief Minister of West Bengal,
Government of West Bengal

Shri Gajendra Singh Shekhawat
Hon’ble Minister of Culture & Tourism,
Government of India



Scan to watch Live

Watch the live telecast on Ministry of Culture’s social media handles

AFTER TRUMP'S 'ONE-SHOT' THREAT TO IRAN

Iran hits back at US, says it has ‘neither civilization, nor honour’

YEREVAN: Iran on Sunday strongly criticised US President Donald Trump after he claimed he could eliminate the nation's senior leadership gathered at the funeral of former Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei in "one shot."

In a sharp retort, the Iranian Embassy in Armenia targeted both Trump and the United States in a post on X. The embassy noted that the US, which observed its 250th Independence Day on July 4, would fail to comprehend the massive wave of grief following Khamenei's death, as it "neither has a civilisation, history, nor honour."

"People can be killed, but ideals cannot. You killed Ayatollah Khamenei, but in reality, you broke a perfume bottle whose scent spread everywhere," the diplomatic mission stated, pointing to the immense turn-outs at the late leader's funeral.

The embassy's reaction followed an interview Trump gave to Axios, in which he expressed astonishment at the thousands of Iranians participating in the funeral processions.



Motorcycles drive past a billboard showing the late Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in Islamic Revolution Square in Tehran on Sunday

I thought people hated Khamenei. Maybe it's fake tears," Trump said.

The US President went on to assert that Washington possesses the capability to neutralise Iran's surviving top officials with "one shot" if

it desired, but specified that the US would hold back to keep the door open for diplomatic talks with Tehran.

They are all there. One shot, and we can take them all out. But we are not going to do that because then

we would have nobody to negotiate with," Trump was quoted as saying by Axios.

The late leader is currently lying in state in Tehran, where crowds of mourners, alongside international dignitaries, are arriving to pay their final

Highlights

- » The embassy's reaction followed an interview Trump gave to Axios
- » The US President went on to assert that Washington possesses the capability to neutralise Iran's surviving top officials
- » The expansive funeral, organised by the Iranian establishment to project domestic solidarity and defiance

respects. The former Supreme Leader, who died following a US-Israeli air strike on February 28, is scheduled to be buried in Mashhad on July 9 after a week of ceremonial processions through Tehran, Qom, Najaf, and Karbala.

The expansive funeral, organised by the Iranian establishment to project domestic solidarity and defiance amid escalating regional tensions, has attracted significant gatherings.

AGENCIES

Calls for revenge

Senior Iranian officials appear in public for supreme leader's funeral



Iran's top officials, including the brothers of Iran's new Supreme Leader, attend funeral prayers over the coffins of the late Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and members of his family in Tehran on Sunday

TEHRAN: Iran's top officials and brothers of the new supreme leader emerged into public view Sunday to attend funeral prayers for Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. Their appearance signalled confidence in their safety as Iran pushes back on US demands in negotiations to permanently end the war.

Crowds of hundreds of thousands chanted "Death to America" and "Death to Israel," as they called for revenge over the Feb. 28 attack that killed the 86-year-old supreme leader and other top officials, triggering the war. Some hard-liners called for the assassination of US President Donald Trump.

Ayatollah Jafar Sobhani, a 97-year-old Shiite cleric, led the prayers at Tehran's Grand Mosque

Iran's new supreme leader, Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei, has yet to make an appearance in the funeral ceremonies, which are unfolding over several days. He is believed to be in hiding after reportedly being wounded in the airstrike that killed his father.

AGENCIES

‘Next round of US–Iran talks likely to be held at Islamabad’

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan capital Islamabad is emerging as the leading venue for the next round of technical negotiations between the US and Iran, a media report said Sunday.

The US and Iran signed the memorandum of understanding (MoU) on June 18, aimed at restoring peace in West Asia. It was followed by technical-level talks in Switzerland on June 21, with Pakistan and Qatar as mediators.

The resumption of the talks is part of ongoing efforts to keep the diplomatic process on track and resolve long standing disputes between Washington and Tehran, Dawn reported quoting diplomatic sources.

"There are two possible venues for the technical talks — Islamabad and the Burgenstock resort in Switzerland," one diplomatic source said.

"Islamabad, however, is the more likely option."

The technical talks are expected to take place on July 11, although a final decision on the venue has yet to be announced.

AGENCIES

Macron to visit Syria

DAMASCUS: French President Emmanuel Macron will visit Syria soon, Syrian state media said on Sunday, making him the first Western leader to arrive in the country since the ouster of former President Bashar Assad in 2024.

Macron hosted Syrian President Ahmad al-Sharaa, the former Islamist leader who seized power in Damascus, in Paris in May 2025, and promised that he would push the European Union and the United States to lift crippling sanctions on Syria, most of which have been removed.

The French presidential palace did not comment on Macron's trip to Syria on Sunday. Syria's state-run SANA news agency, citing al-Sharaa's office, did not give details on when Macron will visit. However, he will be attending a NATO summit in Ankara, Turkey, on Tuesday and Wednesday, Macron will be accompanied by investors and representatives from French companies, SANA said.

The 14-year conflict in Syria has killed nearly half a million people and displaced millions.

AGENCIES

Washington air turns unhealthy after record I-Day fireworks

Amid chants of 'USA, USA', nearly 8.6 lakh pyrotechnic shells were fired from barges on the Potomac River

WASHINGTON: The record-breaking spectacular Independence Day fireworks have led to a sharp deterioration in air quality across the Washington metropolitan area, with local authorities warning citizens about unhealthy air on Sunday.

Air quality maps show several intense PM 2.5 hotspots scattered across the Washington metropolitan area, with the highest pollution levels observed near Capitol Hill and nearby communities.

The Air Quality Index, issued by the Environment Pro-

tection Authority, was in the range of 171 for the national capital on Sunday, more than double what was recorded on Saturday.

On Saturday night, the National Parks Service put on a colossal fireworks display that lasted for nearly 40 minutes to celebrate the 250th anniversary of the Declaration of Independence.

Amid chants of "USA, USA," nearly 8.6 lakh pyrotechnic shells were fired from barges on the Potomac River in what was billed as the largest fire-



Fireworks over the National Mall during an Independence Day event on Sunday in Washington

works display in history.

Last year, the fireworks

barely lasted 10 minutes with 7,000 pyrotechnic shells being

fired. The Metropolitan Washington Council of Governments issued a Code Purple alert for Northern Virginia and the District of Columbia for Sunday following the overnight fireworks.

The alert means the general public may begin to experience health effects from elevated pollution levels, while older adults, children, and people with asthma or other respiratory conditions could face more serious impacts.

Officials are urging residents to limit prolonged

outdoor activity as daytime temperatures are expected to reach 100 degrees Fahrenheit.

In a public advisory, the American Lung Association said the fireworks create smoke filled with tiny particles and gases like sulfur dioxide, carbon dioxide and carbon monoxide, which are "very harmful to our lungs."

George Thurston, a professor of medicine and population health at New York University, was quoted as saying by the Washington Post.

AGENCIES

Business

Decision to drop Adani charges not tied to planned US investments: DoJ

Reports had linked DOJ decision to drop charges to Adani hiring a new legal team led by Robert J Giuffra Jr, one of Trump's personal lawyers

NEW YORK: The US Department of Justice has denied that its decision to drop criminal charges against Indian billionaire Gautam Adani and seven others was linked to the Adani Group's plans to invest about \$10 billion in the United States, saying the prosecution was legally unsustainable and should never have been brought.

In a filing, responding to a federal judge's demand for a fuller explanation, Principal Associate Deputy Attorney General R Trent McCotter rejected media reports suggesting the dismissal was influenced by the conglomerate's investment plans.



"The current or former Department attorneys... have suggested that I sought dismissal of the securities charges at least in part because of some promise by those defendants to invest money in the United States. That is false," McCotter wrote. "I would have sought dis-

Highlights

- » I had already concluded that case should be dropped before the issue was ever raised, Principal Associate Deputy Attorney General R Trent McCotter said
- » McCotter said such stories were 'unethically fed' by current or former Department attorneys

missal of the securities charges regardless of any mentions of investments," he added, saying he had already concluded that the case should be dropped before the issue was ever raised.

"The mention of potential investments could not have played any role."

Reports in US media had

linked the DOJ decision to drop charges altogether to Adani hiring a new legal team led by Robert J Giuffra Jr, one of President Trump's personal lawyers and the co-chairman of the prominent firm Sullivan & Cromwell.

According to a May 14 report in the New York Times, Giuffra had made a presenta-

tion of about 100 slides in meetings at the Justice Department's headquarters in Washington in April this year, outlining why prosecutors lacked basic evidence, as well as the jurisdiction even to bring the case.

In one of the slides, he reportedly made an unusual offer: If prosecutors dropped the charges, Adani would be willing to invest \$10 billion in American economy & create 15,000 jobs, echoing a pledge he had made in the wake of Trump's election last year. McCotter said such stories were "unethically fed" by current or former Department attorneys.

AGENCIES

Govt raises ONGC chairman entry age to 59, offers five-year tenure

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government has relaxed the eligibility conditions for appointing the next chairman of state-owned ONGC by raising the maximum entry age to 59 years and offering the successful candidate a fixed three-year term extendable by up to two years, widening the pool of eligible contenders to head India's largest oil and gas producer.

The Public Enterprises Selection Board (PESB), the government's headhunter for appointments to state-run firms, has invited applications for the post, which will fall vacant on December 7 when incumbent Arun Kumar Singh completes his extended tenure.

Under the Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC) advertisement, candidates should not have attained the age of 59 years on the date of



occurrence of the vacancy — December 7, 2026.

The selected candidate will initially be appointed for three years, with the tenure extendable by another two years after a performance review.

"Any employment or extension of tenure beyond the age of 60 shall be on a contract basis," the advertisement said.

The selection will be made by a search-cum-selection committee constituted by the oil ministry instead of the normal PESB selection process.

The revised age limit marks

a departure from the norms followed for most board-level appointments in Central Public Sector Enterprises (CPSEs).

While recent appointments have largely been governed by a residual service criterion rather than fixed age limits, the advertisement prescribes a maximum entry age of 59 years, allowing both internal and external candidates who would otherwise have been ineligible to be considered.

The tenure conditions are also a departure from the prevailing practice of appointing PSU chiefs until the age of superannuation, which is generally 60 years.

Under the revised framework, a chairman may continue beyond that age on a contractual basis.

The government had made a similar relaxation when appointing Singh in 2022.

Adani Group to invest ₹2,500 crore in missile complex in MP's Shivpuri, create 5,000 jobs

BHOPAL: The Adani Group will invest Rs 2,500 crore over the next three years to establish an integrated missile manufacturing complex in Madhya Pradesh's Shivpuri district, creating 5,000 direct and indirect jobs and developing South Asia's largest private-sector missile ecosystem, Jeet Adani, Director at Adani Airport Holdings Ltd (AAHL), said on Sunday.

Speaking at the foundation stone-laying ceremony attended by Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, Union Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia and other dignitaries, Adani said the facility would bring the production of raw materials and mission-ready missiles under one roof, marking a first for the private sector.

The upcoming complex being set up by Adani Defence & Aerospace will manufacture



Jeet Adani, Director at Adani Airport Holdings Ltd (AAHL)

medium- to long-range missile systems while also producing composite propellants, TNT and explosive-grade materials, helping strengthen India's indigenous defence manufacturing capabilities and reduce dependence on imports.

Adani said the project is part of the group's broader commitment to support the Centre's Aatmanirbhar Bharat initiative

by promoting indigenisation in the defence and aerospace sector in collaboration with the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) and the Armed Forces.

He said the Shivpuri facility builds on the group's defence manufacturing base in Gwalior, where it manufactures light machine guns, assault rifles and carbines.

According to him, the light machine gun programme has already delivered 2,000 units to the Armed Forces, 11 months ahead of schedule.

The Shivpuri project is expected to attract more than 50 MSMEs into a specialised defence supply chain, with Gwalior and Shivpuri together emerging as major defence manufacturing hubs in the state.

Highlighting the group's

broader investments in Madhya Pradesh, Adani said Chairman Gautam Adani had committed Rs 1,10,000 crore at the Global Investors Summit in Bhopal last year across hydro pumped storage, cement, mining, smart meters and thermal energy projects. These investments are expected to generate around 1,20,000 jobs by 2030.

He added that the group has already invested over Rs 4,000 crore in the Ametha and Kymor plants in Katni district, supplies 1,200 MW of power to Madhya Pradesh, and is preparing an additional 5,600 MW of capacity.

It has also commissioned wind energy projects in Lahori, Dhar, Ratlam and Ujjain and recently broke ground for a Rs 1,060 crore cement plant in Guna.

MPOST

IIFCL mobilises ₹1,848 crore by issuing NCDs, strengthens resource base for infra financing

Issue attracted an overwhelming response from investors, attracting bids worth Rs 3,048 crore, nearly 6 times the base issue size of Rs 500 crore

NEW DELHI: India Infrastructure Finance Company Ltd (IIFCL) on Sunday said it has raised Rs 1,848 crore by issuing non-convertible debentures (NCDs) to fund infra projects in the country.

The issue attracted an overwhelming response from investors, attracting bids worth Rs 3,048 crore, representing nearly 6 times the base issue size of Rs 500 crore, IIFCL said. Finally, IIFCL decided to retain Rs 1,848 crore with a coupon of 7.25 per cent/annum. The bonds have a maturity of 4 years, 11 months and 2 days.

The successful issuance reflects the strong confidence of institutional investors in IIFCL's



sound financial position, prudent governance practices and its strategic role as the government's dedicated infrastructure financing institution, it said.

The Board of IIFCL has approved an ambitious resource mobilisation programme of Rs 34,200 crore for 2026-27 to support the growing financing requirements of India's infrastructure sector, it said, adding that the programme envisages

a diversified funding strategy comprising domestic bonds, capital market instruments and external commercial borrowings (ECBs). IIFCL said it is also evaluating opportunities to raise funds through ECBs.

The recent measures announced by the RBI, including the concessional USD-INR swap facility for eligible ECBs, are expected to enhance the attractiveness of overseas borrowings by reducing hedging costs, thereby providing an additional avenue for accessing competitively priced long-term capital, it said.

As part of this strategy, it said, IIFCL plans to access international markets to raise

about \$1.30 billion in the next 2-3 months through External Commercial Borrowings and other debt instruments. The company also expects to raise an additional \$1 billion through overseas borrowings, subject to the necessary approvals from the government and other regulatory authorities, it noted.

Commenting on the successful fund raise, IIFCL Managing Director Rohit Rishi said the overwhelming response to its first bond issuance of the financial year reflects the confidence of the investor community in the company's financial strength, prudent resource management and developmental mandate.

MPOST



CITY: Pg 5

Delhi launches Mission Kayakalp to transform government schools



NATION: Pg 9

Will Champat Rai's fate be decided in Ram temple trust meeting today?



FILM: Pg 11

Celina Jaitley to play Sister Nibedita

Govt issues stern notice to Meta over Instagram child abuse ads

Meta must submit detailed explanation within seven days

VINAY KUMAR

NEW DELHI: The Centre has issued a notice to Meta over allegations that paid advertisements on Instagram promoted or facilitated access to child sexual exploitative and abuse material (CSEAM), marking another round of regulatory action against the social media giant. The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) has ordered Instagram to remove all advertisements and content linked to such material, sought a detailed explanation within seven days, and asked the company to explain how the advertisements were approved despite its stated policies. The move follows a BBC investigation that alleged Meta's recommendation system amplified videos containing child sexual abuse material (CSAM) and that paid advertisements on Facebook and Instagram directed users to illegal content.

Government sources said the notice was issued on Saturday evening after IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw directed MeitY officials a day earlier to summon Meta over the allegations.

According to sources, the ministry has directed Instagram to disable all adver-

HIGHLIGHTS

- » MeitY orders removal of CSEAM-linked ads and content
- » Government seeks answers on approval of objectionable advertisements
- » BBC report alleged Meta algorithm promoted child abuse material
- » Instagram ads allegedly re-directed users to Telegram channels
- » Officials seek safeguards to prevent similar incidents
- » Government demands



action against alleged algorithmic amplification

» Meta cannot cite third party defence for paid advertisements

tisements and content that promote or facilitate access to CSEAM while providing details of the action already taken by the company. Officials have also sought information on safeguards Meta plans to introduce to prevent similar incidents in future.

The notice reportedly asks Meta to explain how advertisements containing terms such as "rape video" and "child video" were allowed on the platform. The BBC investigation alleged that such advertisements redirected users to Telegram channels where child sexual abuse

material was being offered for sale.

Government sources said the ministry is also seeking immediate corrective measures against what it described as the "algorithmic amplification" of CSEAM. Officials are expected to examine both the technical and regulatory aspects of the matter.

Sources said Meta cannot rely on the defence that the content was uploaded by third parties if the allegations involve paid advertisements from which the platform earns revenue.

Govt extends deadline on WhatsApp username feature to July 9

NEW DELHI: The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology has given Meta three more days to respond to questions about WhatsApp's proposed username feature, extending the deadline to July 9, a government official said on Sunday. Earlier, the company had been asked to submit its reply by July 6. According to people familiar with the matter, the notice sought a detailed explanation of the feature, which would allow users to send messages without sharing their phone numbers. Meta has said a username is different from a display name shown on a user's profile. While display names need not be unique, each username will be linked to only one account. Sources earlier said the government has asked Meta not to launch the feature in India until consultations conclude.

MP0ST

depicting children in sexually explicit acts.

The government has maintained that it follows a zero-tolerance approach towards online child sexual abuse material and expects digital platforms to detect, remove and report such content without delay. Authorities have also blocked websites carrying child sexual abuse material in the past using lists received from Interpol through the Central Bureau of Investigation, India's national nodal agency for the international police organisation.

Continued on P6

Monsoon batters India, Mumbai hit hardest

Flights delayed, roads flooded as IMD warns of more rain

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Heavy monsoon rain disrupted normal life across large parts of India on Sunday, grounding flights in Mumbai, flooding roads, triggering alerts for floods and landslides in Kerala, and prompting authorities in several states to prepare for more heavy rainfall over the coming days.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) said a well marked low pressure area over the Bay of Bengal had intensified into a depression and was expected to cross the north Odisha coast within the next 24 hours. The system is likely to bring widespread heavy to very heavy rainfall across eastern India and keep the monsoon active over eastern, central and parts of northern India.

Mumbai faced the worst impact as intense overnight rain and strong winds forced the suspension of runway operations at Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport for about an hour. Four IndiGo flights were cancelled, while 13 incoming flights were diverted before later returning to the airport. Flight tracking data showed nearly 90 per cent of departing flights were delayed by an average of more than an hour, while almost half of arriving



People wade through a waterlogged stretch of SV Road during heavy monsoon rains, in Mumbai

PTI

Six killed, one injured in chawl collapse in Mumbai

MUMBAI: At least six persons were killed and one sustained injuries when a three-storey chawl (row tenement) collapsed in Mumbai's Mankhurd area amid heavy rains on Sunday night, officials said.

One person is feared trapped under the debris, and a multi-agency operation, including personnel from the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF),

is underway to locate him, they said.

As per officials from the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC), four women and a man were "brought dead" to the civic-run Shatabdi Hospital. Another man was declared dead at Rajawadi Hospital.

One injured man is being treated at the BMC-run Rajawadi, they said.

Continued on P6

flights also suffered delays. The IMD continued its red alert for Mumbai after several areas received more than

200 mm of rainfall, with some locations recording nearly 300 mm in 24 hours. Heavy rain led to

Continued on P6

Newlywed woman dies after fall from third floor in Lodhi Colony



PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 28-year-old newlywed, Akriti, died after allegedly falling from the third floor of NDMC Flats in Delhi's Lodhi Colony on Saturday. Police said she was taken to AIIMS, where she was declared dead. Married on April 24, she worked as a sales executive in Chhatarpur. As the death occurred within seven years of marriage, an SDM inquest has begun. Her family alleged dowry harassment, physical abuse and murder, while police said the inquiry and witness statements are underway.

See P4

AS LNG SUPPLIES NORMALISE

Govt withdraws emergency gas curbs imposed during Hormuz disruption

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: The Centre has withdrawn most provisions of the emergency natural gas supply regulations introduced during the recent West Asia conflict after liquefied natural gas (LNG) shipments through the Strait of Hormuz resumed following a ceasefire.

In a notification issued on Saturday, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas amended the Natural Gas (Supply Regulation) Order, 2026, removing key operational provisions that had allowed the government to control the allocation of domestically produced natural



gas and imported LNG according to a revised priority list.

The emergency order, issued on March 9 under the Essential Commodities Act, came after the conflict in West Asia disrupted LNG shipments through the Strait of Hormuz. Some suppliers invoked force majeure clauses and diverted cargoes to

Continued on P6

15 vessels with fertilizer cross Hormuz safely

NEW DELHI: India's fertilizer supply chain has remained largely stable despite the recent conflict in West Asia, with 15 of the 20 vessels carrying fertilizers and raw materials to India safely crossing the Strait of Hormuz, the Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers said on Sunday.

Continued on P6

Baruipur minor's 'rape-murder': One lynched, one held

Incident triggers violent unrest, police attacked, SIT formed, several detained

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: After the mutilated body of a 12-year-old girl was recovered from a pond in Baruipur, South 24-Parganas, widespread violence erupted in the area, triggering public outrage that turned into attacks on police per-

sonnel, arson and prolonged disruption of rail and road traffic. The irate mob allegedly lynched a local youth on suspicion of his involvement.

As alleged by the family members, the minor was 'gang-raped' and 'murdered' by a few youths.

On Sunday night, police

arrested a local youth, identified as Prabhas Mondal, an alleged BJP worker, in connection with the alleged rape-murder case. A special investigation team (SIT) has been formed to probe the case.

The victim, who had gone missing on Saturday afternoon after

Continued on P6

SIT suspects jewellery offered at Ram Temple may have been melted and altered

Officials say findings remain preliminary pending completion of the investigation

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing the alleged misappropriation of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya suspects that some of the jewellery offered by devotees may have been melted and altered, raising fresh questions over the handling of valuables donated to the shrine.

Sources associated with the investigation said the SIT has found indications that the original form of some donated ornaments may have been changed after they were deposited with the temple



authorities. Investigators are examining whether the jewellery was melted and subsequently diverted or tampered with. Officials, however, said the findings are preliminary and any conclusions will

depend on the outcome of the ongoing investigation.

The SIT returned to Lucknow on Friday night after completing the second phase of its two-day inquiry in Ayodhya. The team is scru-

tinising nearly five years of financial records, including bank accounts, transactions and audit documents since the formation of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust.

Continued on P6

CLOSER LOOK

- » SIT completed the second phase of its Ayodhya inquiry
- » Team returned to Lucknow after a two-day investigation
- » Nearly five years of trust financial records are under scrutiny
- » Bank accounts, transactions and audit documents are being examined
- » Investigators suspect donation amounts were manipulated during counting



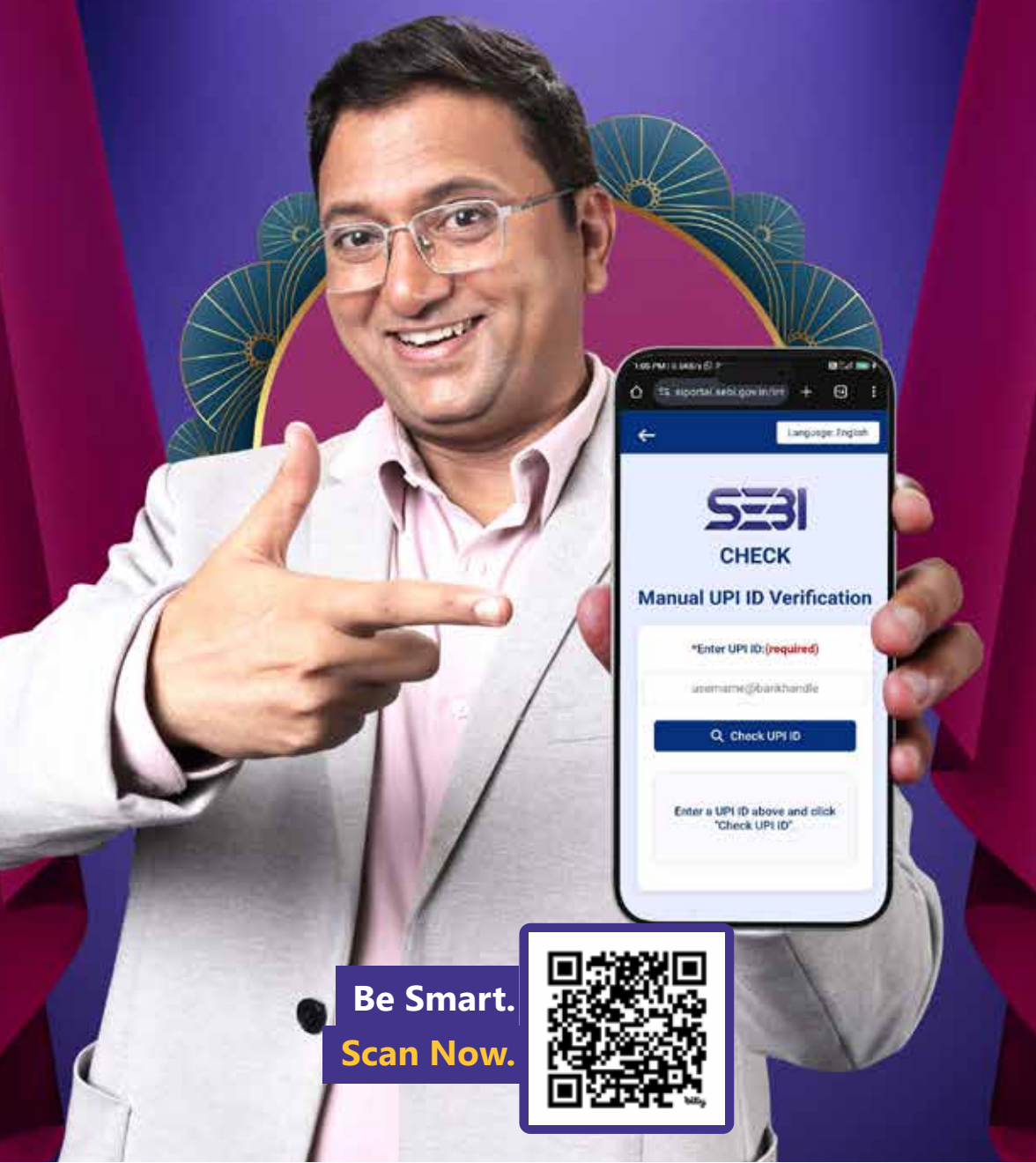
SEBI
Securities and Exchange Board of India



NSE
IPFT

**PAYMENT TAB KARO
JAB SEBICHECK KARO**

SEBI INTRODUCES "VALIDATED UPI HANDLES"
TO ENABLE SECURED PAYMENTS



Be Smart.
Scan Now.



Download the Saaṛthi App
#SEBICheck

POST-MORTEM REPORT EXPECTED TO SHED LIGHT ON CAUSE OF DEATH

Newlywed dies after fall from Lodhi Colony flats, kin allege dowry killing

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 28-year-old newlywed woman died after allegedly falling from the third floor of the NDMC Flats in South Delhi's Lodhi Colony under mysterious circumstances on Saturday evening, with her family accusing her husband and in-laws of murdering her over alleged dowry demands.

Police were alerted to the incident through a PCR call received at Lodhi Colony Police Station. The woman, identified as Akriti Sutar, a resident of Pushp Vihar, was found critically injured and rushed to the AIIMS Trauma Centre, where she was declared brought dead.

Police have initiated proceedings under Section 196 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), while the Sub-Divisional Magistrate has been



informed for inquest proceedings. A post-mortem examination is under way. Akriti, who worked as a sales executive in Chhatarpur, had married Arastu Sikka on April 24 after the two had reportedly known each other for nearly eight years. Investigators said

they are examining all possible angles, including the circumstances that led to her presence at the residential complex, located around 10 kilometres from her matrimonial home.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (South) Anant Mittal said the woman was found

CLOSER LOOK

» Police have initiated proceedings under Section 196 of BNSS, while the Sub-Divisional Magistrate has been informed for inquest proceedings

» A post-mortem examination is under way. Akriti, who worked as a sales executive in Chhatarpur, had married Arastu Sikka on April 24 after the two had known each other for eight years

» They are examining all possible angles, including circumstances that led to her presence at the residential complex, 10 kilometers from her matrimonial home

injured after an alleged fall from the residential complex and that the investigation remains open. "All aspects of the incident are being verified. The inquiry is in progress," he said.

Rejecting the possibility of suicide, Akriti's family alleged

that she had been subjected to repeated harassment over dowry following her marriage. They claimed that her husband and his family had demanded Rs 20 lakh and had threatened her on multiple occasions. Her brother said she was mentally strong and would never have taken her own life.

The family further claimed that Akriti had spoken to her mother shortly after leaving work on Saturday evening. They alleged that her husband later informed them she was missing before police contacted them about the incident. They also questioned why her body was found at a largely unoccupied residential complex and claimed the absence of bloodstains at the scene raised suspicion. They said the post-mortem report would be crucial in determining the exact cause of her death.

Man kills wife with 'tawa', held

Woman killed in Najafgarh; man surrenders at PS

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 48-year-old man undergoing treatment for schizophrenia allegedly surrendered at BHD Nagar Police Station after killing his 43-year-old wife with a tawa during a domestic dispute in Delhi's Najafgarh, police said.

The deceased has been identified as Sarita (43), while the accused, Dinesh Patel (48), is a resident of Gopal Nagar in Najafgarh.

According to police, Dinesh arrived at the police station during the intervening night of July 4 and 5 and informed the duty officer that he had killed his wife. Acting on his statement, a police team rushed to the couple's residence, where Sarita was found dead.

During questioning, Dinesh told investigators that he had been suffering from schizophrenia and had been undergoing treatment at Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital for the past two to three years.

Police, however, said they are continuing their investigation to establish the exact



Dinesh arrived at the police station on the intervening night of July 4 and 5; he told the duty officer he had killed his wife

sequence of events and the circumstances leading to the alleged murder.

Preliminary inquiries revealed that the couple had married in 2005 and have two sons. Their elder son is preparing for engineering entrance examinations, while the

younger is a Class 5 student. Police said Dinesh had been employed with an IT company but had been unemployed for the past two months. Investigators also found that Sarita's relatives live in the same Gopal Nagar locality.

During interrogation, the accused allegedly said he had been distressed over his circumstances and frequently argued with his wife over minor issues. Police said another argument broke out on Saturday night, during which he allegedly struck her with a tawa in a fit of anger, causing fatal injuries.

A forensic science team and the crime team inspected the scene and collected evidence.

The accused has been detained and a case has been registered under Section 103(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), which pertains to murder.

Senior police officers said further investigation is under way, including examining whether the accused's medical condition had any bearing on the incident.

Police bust illegal SIM racket, PoS agent held

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police Cyber Cell has arrested a licensed telecom Point of Sale (PoS) agent for allegedly activating SIM cards illegally by bypassing mandatory KYC and biometric verification and supplying them to cyber fraudsters across the country.

The accused, identified as Shiva, a resident of Siddharthnagar district in Uttar Pradesh, was arrested near Hindu Rao Hospital on July 2. Police said he operated a licensed outlet, Shivam Telecom, from a temporary roadside stall.

The investigation began after intelligence inputs revealed that SIM cards activated by certain PoS agents in Delhi were repeatedly being used in cyber fraud cases nationwide. Police found that 11 SIM cards activated through Shivam Telecom alone were linked to 18 cyber fraud complaints. During interrogation, the accused allegedly admitted to using customers' identity documents and biometric credentials to activate additional SIM cards without their knowledge before selling them to cyber criminals. Further investigation is under way to identify other members.



Wanted gangsters killed in Delhi-Hry joint encounter

Duo wanted in Hansi gym trainer murder carried Rs 1 lakh reward each; constable injured

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two alleged members of the Lawrence Bishnoi-linked Harimam alias Harry Boxer-Anil Pandit organised crime syndicate, each carrying a reward of Rs 1 lakh, were killed in an exchange of fire with a joint team of the Delhi Police Special Cell and the Haryana Police Special Task Force (STF), police said on Sunday.

According to police, the operation was launched following a tip-off received by the Delhi Police Special Cell about the movement of the accused. It also led to the registration of a case under the Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime

Act (MCOCA) against the syndicate as part of a wider crackdown on its criminal network.

The deceased, identified as Pravesh and Himanshu, both residents of Hisar in Haryana, were wanted in connection with the June 11 murder of a gym trainer in Hansi. The killing, captured on CCTV, had prompted the Haryana Police to announce a reward of Rs 1 lakh on each accused. They were also named in an FIR registered by the Special Cell.

Police said intelligence inputs suggested the duo was moving within Haryana, prompting a joint operation with the STF. After tracking them near Bahadurgarh, the police team surrounded the



Op followed arrest of two other members of the same syndicate

suspects and asked them to surrender. Officials alleged that the duo instead opened fire, forcing the police to retaliate

in self-defence.

Both men sustained gunshot injuries and were taken to a nearby hospital, where they were declared dead. During the operation, Constable Ankit of the Special Cell sustained a gunshot injury to his leg. Police said his condition is stable and the injury is not life-threatening.

Senior Haryana Police officers, along with forensic experts and the crime team, inspected the scene, and a fresh FIR has been registered at Sadar Bahadurgarh Police Station.

Police said the operation followed the arrest of two other alleged members of the same syndicate, Hakikat alias

Sahil and Sagar, after an armed encounter in Delhi on June 25. The duo is accused of opening fire outside singer Guru Randhawa's gym in Paschim Vihar on June 11 and remains in police custody.

According to investigators, their interrogation provided crucial leads that helped trace Pravesh and Himanshu and establish links between the Delhi firing and the Hansi murder. Officials said the newly registered MCOCA case is aimed at dismantling the syndicate's financial and logistical network and enabling legal action against absconding gang leaders, including Harry Boxer and Anil Pandit, who are believed to be operating from abroad.

DTC bus collision claims biker's life

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 38-year-old motorcyclist was killed after a Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) bus allegedly collided with his motorcycle near GTB Enclave Police Station in northeast Delhi on Sunday afternoon. Police said they received a PCR call about the accident at around 12.05 pm and rushed to the spot, located in front of the police station, where they found the DTC bus and the motorcycle involved in the collision.

The deceased was identified as Sandeep (38), a resident of Pappu Colony in Sahibabad, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh. He sustained a severe head injury and was declared dead at the scene, police said.

The bus driver was identified, taken into custody and later arrested. Police said legal proceedings have been initiated against him. The body has been shifted to Guru Teg Bahadur (GTB) Hospital for a post-mortem examination.

Investigators inspected the accident site, collected evidence and seized both the motorcycle and the DTC bus for examination. Police are investigating the sequence of events leading to the collision and whether negligence or violation of traffic rules contributed to the crash.

Officials said they will record the statements of witnesses and examine available CCTV footage from the area to reconstruct the incident. Further investigation is under way.

NOIDA: Woman jumps to death from Sector 18 parking complex

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: A 49-year-old woman allegedly died by suicide after jumping from an upper floor of a multilevel parking facility in Sector 18 on Saturday afternoon. Police are reconstructing her final movements using CCTV footage, though the exact point from which she jumped remains unclear as there are no surveillance cameras covering that area.

The deceased, identified as Situ Talwar, was a resident of Sector 20. She is survived by her husband, Mohit Talwar, a retired Indian Air Force Wing Commander who now runs a business, and their son, a Class XII student at a private school in Noida.

According to investigators, Situ arrived at the Sector 18 parking complex in an e-rickshaw at around 2 pm. CCTV footage shows her entering the six-storey parking facility and proceeding towards the upper levels. Police said she spent a few minutes inside before allegedly jumping.

Passersby alerted the police through the Dial 112 emergency helpline. Officers rushed to the spot and shifted her to a private hospital in Sector 27, where she was declared brought dead.

Assistant Commissioner of Police (Noida Zone I) Praveen Singh said preliminary inquiries revealed that the woman had been undergoing treatment for depression at a private

hospital in Delhi for nearly 20 years. Her family, however, told investigators that she had never previously attempted suicide.

Police said the investigation is focused on reconstructing her movements inside the parking facility. In the absence of CCTV coverage at the suspected jump site, officers are relying on footage from entry and exit points and other sections of the building.

Officials suspect she jumped from either the first or second floor, though this has not yet been confirmed. No complaint had been lodged by the family till Sunday evening. The body has been sent for a post-mortem examination, and further legal proceedings are under way.

Uttam Ngr man nabbed for abducting 17-yr-old

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 22-year-old man has been arrested for allegedly kidnapping a 17-year-old girl from northeast Delhi's Gokulpuri area, with police safely rescuing the minor during the investigation.

The accused, identified as Karan (22), a resident of Uttam Nagar, was arrested following a complaint lodged at Gokulpuri Police Station by the girl's mother. According to police, the woman reported on June 23 that her daughter had been missing since June 20 despite repeated efforts by the family to trace her. Suspecting that she had been abducted, she sought police intervention.

An FIR was registered under Section 137(2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), and a police team launched an investigation using technical surveillance, electronic evidence and local intelligence to trace the girl.

Acting on technical inputs,



the team located the victim and arrested the accused. The minor was rescued safely during the operation.

During interrogation, Karan allegedly confessed to his involvement in the offence. Police also recovered the mobile phone allegedly used in the crime from his possession.

Following the recovery of the victim and the recording of her statement, investigators invoked additional charges under Sections 64(1) and 87 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, along with Section 4 of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act. Police said the accused has no previous criminal record and further investigation is under way.

UG, PG AND INTEGRATED ADMISSIONS UNDERWAY

Delhi University opens admissions for new 1-year postgraduate programmes

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The University of Delhi (DU) has announced the commencement of admissions for its newly introduced one-year postgraduate programmes and invited applications for its M.Sc. in Plant Molecular Biology and Biotechnology (PMB) through the Graduate Aptitude Test-Biotechnology (GAT-B), while the ongoing undergraduate and postgraduate admission processes continue to witness a strong response.

The newly launched one-year postgraduate programmes are open exclusively to students who have completed a four-year undergraduate degree under the Undergraduate Curriculum Framework (UGCF) 2022, based on the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, from the University of Delhi.



Admissions will be based on the merit secured in the four-year bachelor's programme according to the programme-specific eligibility criteria. Applications for both the one-year PG courses and the two-year M.Sc. PMB programme are being accepted through the university's postgraduate admission portal.

For undergraduate admissions under the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS), the university has received 1,48,407 applications, with 62,524 can-

Univ has also released updates on two-yr postgraduate admissions, where 9,500 admissions have already been completed

didates completing Phase II of the admission process so far. Candidates can submit and edit their programme and college preferences until 11:59 p.m. on July 11.

The university has also released updates on two-year postgraduate admissions, where 9,500 admissions have already been completed. The mid-entry window will close at 11:59 p.m. on July 5, while the third allocation list, including admissions to performance-based programmes such as

Master of Fine Arts (MFA), Bachelor of Physical Education (B.P.Ed.), Master of Physical Education (M.P.Ed.) and Music, will be announced on July 9.

For B.Tech admissions, DU has declared the second allocation list, and shortlisted candidates have until 4:59 p.m. on July 8 to accept their allotted seats.

Meanwhile, the first spot admission round for the five-year integrated law programmes is underway. Eligible candidates can apply for the spot round until 11:59 p.m. on July 7. With admissions progressing simultaneously across undergraduate, postgraduate, professional and integrated programmes, the university has advised applicants to adhere strictly to the notified deadlines to avoid missing admission opportunities.

News at a Glance

METRO STALKER CAUGHT AT PATEL NGR

NEW DELHI: A man was apprehended for allegedly stalking a woman on the Delhi Metro after a complaint was made to the CISF's 24x7 helpline 1556555. Acting on alerts from the woman's mother and later the complainant herself, CISF personnel tracked the suspect using his photograph and intercepted him at Patel Nagar Metro Station. He was subsequently taken into custody by the Delhi Metro Rail Police for further legal action. The CISF said the incident highlighted the effectiveness of its helpline and coordination with the Delhi Metro Rail Police in ensuring passenger safety.

PASSENGERS HELD FOR ROBBING CABBIE

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have arrested three men for allegedly robbing a taxi driver of his car and mobile phone in the Welcome area, officials said on Sunday. The incident took place on June 22 when the accused allegedly hired the taxi from northeast Delhi for Loni Gol Chakkar. During the journey, they allegedly pushed the driver out near the Bhopura border and fled with the vehicle and his mobile phone. Police identified and arrested Mehtab (29), Aman (22) and Md Faisal (23) after analysing CCTV footage, technical surveillance and local intelligence. The stolen vehicle was later recovered, and further investigation into the case is under way.

Delhi launches Mission Kayakalp to transform government schools

Initiative focuses on infrastructure, sanitation, laboratories and inclusive facilities

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major push to upgrade government school infrastructure, the Delhi government has rolled out 'Mission Kayakalp', a comprehensive initiative aimed at transforming schools across the capital into modern, safe and student-friendly campuses. Announcing the initiative on Sunday, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the programme seeks to create inspiring learning spaces through extensive renovation, improved facilities and community participation.

The initiative focuses on addressing long-pending infrastructure gaps such as repairs, painting, waterproofing, modern science laboratories, clean drinking water facilities, roof-top drainage, greenery and improved amenities for students, including children with special needs. Improvement works are already underway or have been completed in schools across multiple districts of the capital. Announcing the initiative, the Chief Minister said, "Our goal is to



make government schools not just centres of education, but modern and inspiring learning spaces for children."

She said Mission Kayakalp is being implemented with the support of district administrations, the Education Department, corporate organisations through Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR), social organisations, market associations and local communities. According to Gupta, public participation alongside government resources has helped

accelerate infrastructure development in schools across Delhi. Highlighting the scale of the programme, the Chief Minister said the campaign was far more than a painting drive. "Mission Kayakalp is not limited to painting alone but is a comprehensive campaign to transform government schools," she said.

Under the initiative, infrastructure works have been carried out in several districts. In North Delhi, a sensory park for children with special needs at a government school on Shan-

HIGHLIGHTS

- » CM said Mission Kayakalp is being implemented with the support of dist admins, Edu Dept, corporate organisations through CSR, social orgs, market associations and local communities
- » According to Gupta, public participation alongside government resources has helped accelerate infra dev

karacharya Marg has been renovated, while an RO plant and water coolers have been installed. A government school in Roop Nagar has received a modernised physics laboratory.

In South Delhi, extensive renovation has been completed at schools in Mehrauli and Qutub Mehrauli, including repairs to classrooms and roofs, renovation of toilets, replacement of sanitary fittings, repainting of buildings, installation of water coolers and campus beautification

through plantation drives.

Schools in Mohan Garden and Janakpuri in West Delhi are undergoing roof waterproofing, rainwater harvesting, electrical upgrades, installation of RO plants and renovation of sanitation facilities. Similar improvement works have also been completed at schools in Gokulpur, Shahdara and Sawda Ghevra, where infrastructure upgrades include repaired buildings, new water facilities, library improvements, space laboratories and enhanced learning spaces.

Gupta said several schools that previously suffered from deteriorating infrastructure had already undergone a visible transformation. "The work being carried out under Mission Kayakalp has already transformed several government schools," she said, adding that the government would continue strengthening school infrastructure so that every government school in Delhi evolves into a model institution offering a safe, modern and inspiring environment for learning.

DTC expands network with new Route 753 Ext

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government on Sunday launched a new Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) bus service, Route 753 Ext, connecting Mori Gate Terminal with Kheri Baba Pul on an experimental basis to improve public transport connectivity between Central and West Delhi. The service, which began operations from July 5, is expected to benefit commuters from Janakpuri, Vikas Puri, Uttam Nagar, Hastal, Shiv Vihar, Hari Nagar and adjoining areas by providing direct access to Mori Gate ISBT.

Announcing the launch, Delhi Transport Minister Dr. Pankaj Kumar Singh said the initiative was part of the government's efforts to strengthen the city's public transport network and make commuting more convenient for residents.

"The launch of Route 753 Ext is another step towards our vision of providing seamless, affordable and accessible public transport to every citizen of Delhi. The new route will improve daily connectivity between Central and West Delhi while offering significant convenience to the Purvanchal community travelling through the city's major interstate transport hubs," the minister said.



He added that under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, the Delhi government was continuously expanding public transport services to make commuting safer, more convenient and citizen-centric.

"The newly introduced route will significantly improve accessibility for residents of Janakpuri, Vikas Puri, Hastal, Shiv Vihar, Uttam Nagar, Hari Nagar and adjoining localities by providing them with a direct and affordable public transport connection to Central Delhi and Mori Gate," Singh said.

According to the government, Route 753 Ext will operate between Mori Gate Terminal and Kheri Baba Pul via key locations including Red Fort, Delhi Gate, Paharganj, Karol Bagh, Rajendra Place, Shadipur, Naraina, Maya Puri, Janakpuri, Uttam Nagar, Vikas

Puri, Hastal and Shiv Vihar.

DTC officials said the route has been designed to serve office-goers, students, senior citizens and daily commuters while improving connectivity to educational institutions, hospitals, employment centres, Metro stations and major interchange points.

The government said the route's direct connectivity to Mori Gate ISBT and Kashmir Gate would particularly benefit members of the Purvanchal community by providing easier access to interstate bus services and nearby railway stations, reducing the need for multiple transfers during long-distance travel. Officials said the launch of Route 753 Ext was part of the government's broader efforts to expand Delhi's public transport network and improve commuter convenience across the city.

SIR: 62L+ enumeration forms distributed so far, around 2L digitised

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: More than 42 per cent of the capital's 1.45 crore voters have been distributed enumeration forms, while just over 1.4 per cent of completed forms have been digitised during the first six days of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of Delhi electoral rolls, according to official data.

A total of 62,27,363 enumeration forms were distributed across the capital and 2,09,201 completed forms were digitised till Sunday evening, data shared by the office of the Delhi chief electoral officer (CEO) showed.

The distribution covered 42.92 per cent of Delhi's 1,45,10,298 registered electors, while the digitised forms accounted for 1.44 per cent of the total electorate.

Meanwhile, the Delhi CEO's office said in a post on X that former President Ram Nath Kovind submitted his filled enumeration form as part of the SIR 2026 exercise, which was received by the electoral registration officer (ERO) of the New Delhi assembly constituency.

The month-long door-to-door survey under SIR Phase III began June 30 and will continue till July 29.

Among districts, North East recorded the highest number of forms distributed at 8,19,265, followed by West



(6,86,646), East (6,19,563), South (5,65,252) and South East (5,43,348).

In percentage terms, New Delhi led districts with 56.43 per cent electors covered, followed by North (51.54 per cent), Old Delhi (50.94 per cent) and North West (49.51 per cent).

South East recorded the lowest distribution percentage at 34.89 per cent, followed by Central (37.62 per cent), South West (37.94 per cent) and East (38.64 per cent).

In terms of digitisation, South West topped the list with 35,405 forms digitised, followed by Outer North (28,220), West (27,405), South (19,078) and Central North (15,831).

Outer North recorded the highest digitisation rate at 3.39 per cent, while Central was the lowest at 0.76 per cent. Under the Special Intensive Revision, voters must submit the enumeration form for inclusion in the electoral roll. No supporting documents are required with the form.

PM Modi's leadership has transformed governance and development: Speaker

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Addressing a Sanskritik Sandhya organised in Rohini to commemorate twelve years of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership, Delhi Legislative Assembly Speaker Vijendra Gupta on Sunday said the Prime Minister's tenure had redefined the scale and pace of India's development through decisive governance, infrastructure expansion, digital transformation and welfare-oriented policies, while placing public welfare at the centre of governance.

Union Minister of State for Housing and Urban Affairs Tokhan Sahu and Delhi Mayor Praveesh Wahi were among those present at the programme, which was attended by public representatives, members of social organ-



isations and residents from the Rohini Assembly constituency.

Addressing the gathering, the Speaker said, "Over the past twelve years, Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi's leadership has redefined the scale and pace of India's development while placing public welfare at the centre of governance."

He said the period had witnessed major advancements in infrastructure, digital governance and welfare delivery. According to Gupta, the government's emphasis on transparency, efficient service

'The period had witnessed major advancements in infrastructure, digital governance and welfare delivery'

delivery and citizen-centric policymaking had contributed to strengthening public confidence in governance.

Referring to the government's initiatives over the past decade, Gupta said, "The past twelve years have been marked by decisive governance, rapid infrastructure development, digital transformation, expanded social welfare initiatives and a renewed emphasis on inclusive growth." He added that these efforts had accelerated India's progress towards becoming a developed nation.

The Speaker also underscored the importance of public participation in democratic governance. "Public participation remains the foundation of democratic governance and nation-building," he said, expressing confidence that India would continue to advance towards the goal of Viksit Bharat under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, guided by the principles of Vishwas, Vikas and Jan Kalyan.

The cultural programme featured devotional bhajans celebrating India's civilisational heritage and artistic traditions. According to the organisers, the event brought together people from diverse sections of society in an atmosphere of devotion and cultural harmony while commemorating twelve years of the Prime Minister's leadership.

AAP accuses BJP govt of shifting blame in health scam

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Saturday alleged that the purported Rs 650-crore health scam in Delhi was not a systemic failure but a deliberate act by the BJP government, accusing the Rekha Gupta-led administration of attempting to shift the blame after the matter came to light.

Delhi AAP chief Saurabh

Bharadwaj outlined what he described as the chronology of the case, claiming that then Director General of Health Services (DGHS) Dr Vandana Bagga had flagged major irregularities in a 2025 tender for outsourced laboratory testing services across government hospitals, dispensaries and clinics. According to Bharadwaj, Dr Bagga recorded on the file that the tender had been tailored to favour a particular

vendor and alleged that she was pressured by then Health Secretary Dr S.B. Deepak Kumar and Special Secretary Danish to approve it.

Bharadwaj alleged that Dr Bagga refused to clear the tender and was subsequently suspended by Lieutenant Governor Vinai Saxena. He claimed that her successor, Dr Rati Makkar, also faced pressure to approve the tender but declined and opted for vol-

untary retirement. According to him, Dr Vatsala Aggarwal was later appointed DGHS by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and the Lieutenant Governor, following which the alleged Rs 650-crore scam surfaced. He further claimed that Dr Bagga challenged her suspension in the Supreme Court, won the case and was reinstated in the Health Department.

In a separate post on X, Bharadwaj alleged that the

NEW DELHI: Delhi recorded its warmest July day in two years on Sunday, with the maximum temperature reaching 38.6 degrees Celsius, two notches above normal and the highest since July 11, 2024. Moderate afternoon showers brought relief to parts of the city, with Chhatrapur receiving 49 mm of rainfall till 2.30 pm, the highest in Delhi-NCR, leading to waterlogging in the area.

The IMD has issued an orange alert for Monday, forecasting a generally cloudy sky with moderate rain and temperatures between 32 and 27 degrees Celsius. The minimum temperature on Sunday was 29.2 degrees Celsius, also the highest for July since 2024. Delhi's AQI remained in the 'moderate' category at 155. Weather experts expect more typical monsoon rainfall in the coming days.

MP0ST

Court discharges man in fake Malaysian visa case

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court has set aside charges against a man under the Passports Act for allegedly possessing a fake Malaysian visa, holding that there was no evidence linking the document to any offence committed in India. Additional Sessions Judge Saurabh Parth Singh Laler ruled that the prosecution had failed to establish that the visa was forged, procured or used in India, or that the accused had ever travelled to or attempted to travel to Malaysia.

The court observed that criminal charges cannot rest on conjecture or suspicion alone and said the unexplained presence of the visa sticker in the passport was insufficient to constitute an offence. It also noted that no material showed the visa was affixed in India before the accused's departure. Accordingly, the court discharged the accused under the relevant provisions of the Passports Act.

'25,000+ SAPLINGS PLANTED SO FAR' Tree care key to greener Delhi, says NDMC at plantation drive

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on Sunday marked the 31st consecutive week of its Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam plantation campaign with a community tree-planting drive at B.D. Park in B.K. Dutt Colony, where officials, Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs) and residents stressed that long-term care of saplings is as important as planting them.

Leading the programme, NDMC Vice-Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal said the campaign, inspired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's initiative, has evolved into a weekly public movement. He said over 25,000 saplings, including trees and shrubs, have been planted under NDMC drives so far, though he did not share survival-rate data when asked whether the figures would be made public.

RWA president Harbans Dunkal said dedicating a tree to one's mother creates an emo-



tional connection that encourages people to care for saplings. Calling rising temperatures and climate change a growing concern, he urged citizens to plant more trees and educate younger generations about environmental conservation. He also alleged that lapses by agencies responsible for protecting green cover and corruption have contributed to unchecked tree felling in some areas. RWA member said protecting existing trees should receive equal priority, arguing that indiscriminate felling for infrastructure projects

has accelerated environmental degradation.

Health Sanitary Inspector Raju Deeka described the campaign as a positive initiative but said its success depends on public participation beyond ceremonial plantation. While acknowledging that development projects such as Metro expansion require land, he stressed that planted saplings often perish due to poor maintenance. "Planting must be followed by regular care," he said, adding that sustained community involvement is essential to improve the city's green cover.

Gujranwala Town Park renamed in memory of DJ Sachdeva: MCD

'Tribute recognises lifelong commitment to public service'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Sunday dedicated a public park in Gujranwala Town, Keshav Puram Zone, to the memory of noted social worker Late D.J. Sachdeva, with Mayor Praveesh Wahi describing the move as a tribute to a life devoted to public service and community welfare.

The inauguration ceremony was attended by MLA Ashok Goel Deoraha, Keshav Puram Zone Chairman Vikesh Sethi, municipal councillors, members of social and religious organisations, representatives of the Sachdeva family and local residents.

Addressing the gathering, Wahi said that individuals who dedicate themselves to society continue to inspire generations through their work and values. He said naming the park after Sachdeva was not merely a symbolic gesture but a recognition of his contribution to the community and an effort to

KEY POINTS

- » The inauguration ceremony was attended by MLA Ashok Goel Deoraha, Keshav Puram Zone Chairman Vikesh Sethi, municipal councillors, members of social and religious organisations, representatives of the Sachdeva family and local residents
- » Addressing the gathering, Wahi said that individuals who dedicate themselves to society continue to inspire generations through their work and values

encourage younger generations to embrace the ideals of service and social responsibility.

The Mayor also underlined the role of parks as more than recreational spaces, describing them as centres for community interaction, environmental

conservation and public wellbeing. He said the MCD plans to upgrade parks across the city through multiple models, including Public-Private Partnerships (PPP), collaborations with Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs) and support from the Delhi government.

Wahi said the civic body is working to expand green spaces, improve sanitation and strengthen civic infrastructure in line with the vision of a cleaner and more sustainable Delhi.

He appealed to residents to actively participate in maintaining parks and public spaces, stressing that community involvement is essential to achieving long-term environmental goals.

Speaking on the occasion, Goel Deoraha, Sethi and other speakers recalled Sachdeva's contribution to social causes and expressed hope that the park would serve as a lasting reminder of his commitment to public welfare and inspire future generations.

Juvenile to be tried as an adult in 2025 murder case

NEW DELHI: The Juvenile Justice Board has directed that a juvenile be tried as an adult in connection with the murder of a 22-year-old man in east Delhi's Shakarpur area in 2025, police said on Sunday.

The board passed the order on July 4 after considering an application moved by the investigating officer, who cited the gravity of the offence and the evidence collected during the probe, an officer said.

The case pertains to the fatal stabbing of a 22-year-old man in Shakarpur Market on December 7, 2025. Police said the victim was taken to the hospital after the attack, but later succumbed to his injuries.

Following the incident, an FIR was registered at the Shakarpur police station, and the investigation was taken up. During the probe, police apprehended a juvenile in connection with the murder.

During the investigation, it emerged that the juvenile was already facing trial in another murder case registered in 2024 and was on bail when the fresh offence was allegedly committed.

Based on the material collected during the investigation, the investigating officer moved an application before the board seeking that the juvenile be tried as an adult under the provisions of the Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act, 2015.

After examining the evidence and other relevant factors under the law, the board allowed the plea to face trial as an adult, police said.

PTI

JAISHANKAR COVERING QATAR, BAHARAIN, KUWAIT AND OMAN

EAM Jaishankar meets Qatar PM, reviews bilateral cooperation

DOHA: External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar met Qatar's Prime Minister Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al-Thani on Sunday and reviewed several areas of bilateral cooperation, including energy, trade, investments, connectivity and security.

Jaishankar is on a visit covering Qatar, Bahrain, Kuwait and Oman from July 5 to 10.

The Gulf visit comes against the backdrop of fast-evolving political dynamics in West Asia following the signing of an agreement aimed at ending the US-Iran conflict.

Jaishankar thanked the Qatar PM for ensuring the safety and well-being of the Indian community in the country.

"Reviewed various facets of our bilateral cooperation especially energy, trade, investments, connectivity, security and people to people



External Affairs minister S Jaishankar meets Qatar Prime Minister and Minister of Foreign Affairs Mohammed bin Abdulrahman bin Jassim Al Thani, in Doha

ties. Explored new opportunities for deepening our Strategic Partnership," Jaishankar posted on X.

Jaishankar also discussed

assessments on the West Asia conflict and its impact with PM Al-Thani, who is also Qatar's foreign minister.

During the ongoing visit,

Highlights

» The Gulf visit comes against the backdrop of fast-evolving political dynamics in West Asia following the signing of an agreement aimed at ending the US-Iran conflict

» Jaishankar thanked the Qatar PM for ensuring the safety and well-being of the Indian community in the country

» Jaishankar also discussed assessments on the West Asia conflict and its impact with PM Al-Thani, who is also Qatar's foreign minister

Jaishankar will meet his counterparts and top leaders of the four Gulf countries to enhance

bilateral relations and exchange views on regional developments and issues of mutual interest.

Qatar and Oman have emerged as mediators, along with Pakistan, in bringing about the Iran ceasefire following weeks of escalating tensions. The indirect talks between the US and Iran in Doha are set to continue after the week-long funeral rites of Iran's slain supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, which started on Friday.

After visiting the four Gulf countries, Jaishankar will travel to New York on July 13 to launch India's official campaign for the UN Security Council tenure 2028-29.

He will then attend the 3rd India-EU Trade and Technology Council meeting in Brussels on July 14-15 and interact with EU and Belgian counterparts.

AGENCIES

INS Sudarshini participates in maritime spectacle in US for 250th anniversary

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Indian Navy's sail training ship -- INS Sudarshini -- carrying the tricolour proudly sailed into the New York port and past the Statue of Liberty on July 4, joining vessels from the US and several other countries for a grand nautical event marking the 250th anniversary of the US' independence.

The ship's presence in the International Naval Review and Sail 4th 250 celebrations hosted by America, also reflects the "enduring friendship, mutual respect, and expanding maritime partnership between India and the United States", the Indian Navy said on Sunday.

America commemorated 250 years of its independence on July 4 with grand celebrations held in Washington and parallel events across the country.

On July 4, 1776, the Second Continental Congress had unanimously adopted the Declaration of Independence, the founding document of America.



Indian Navy's Sail Training Ship, INS Sudarshini sailed into New York Harbour, during the Parade of Sail, representing India at the Sail 250 and US International Naval Review

PTI

The US, being a maritime nation, has also marked the milestone with the grand event -- International Naval Review and Sail 4th 250.

It is a "historic, once-in-a-lifetime gathering of the largest fleet of US and international ships and aircraft in honour of America's 250th birthday", according to the Freedom250's official website.

The International Naval Review showcases America's unrivalled maritime superiority, global leadership, and enduring partnerships through the United States Navy, Marine Corps, and Coast Guard, it says.

"The celebration will also feature the largest-ever flotilla of tall ships from around the world, with vessels representing more than 20 nations creating a breathtaking nautical spectacle across New York Harbour," says the website, according to which the event will be held from July 4-8.

The show in the waters was complemented by an aerial display as US jets streamed across the New York sky, leaving a trail in red, white and blue, as a large number of spectators witnessed the event from the shores, and it was also watched online.

INS Sudarshini sailed into the New York port on July 4 to represent India at the International Naval Review and Sail 4th 250 celebrations of the US, a spokesperson of the Indian Navy said.

From Page 1

Govt issues stern notice

Government sources said any agency, authority or individual may file complaints against advertisers or platforms if they believe offences under the law have been committed. Technology companies have repeatedly been warned that failure to curb child sexual abuse material and other harmful online content could attract regulatory scrutiny and legal action.

Responding to questions on the BBC report, a Meta spokesperson said the company has a zero tolerance policy for soliciting or sharing child sexual abuse material, including in advertisements.

"We use advanced AI technology to proactively detect violating content and individuals, but we are in a constant battle with criminals who hide among our 3.5 billion users and try to evade our detection," the spokesperson said. The spokesperson added that Meta's specialist teams continue to improve detection systems, develop new technologies to identify offenders, block links to violating websites and share intelligence with other companies to help tackle such activity.

The latest notice marks the second time this week that Meta has come under the Centre's scrutiny. Earlier, the government questioned WhatsApp's proposed username feature, saying it could increase risks of online fraud, phishing, impersonation and so called digital arrest scams. The Centre asked the company to pause the rollout until consultations were completed and sought an explanation on why action should not be initiated under the Information Technology Act and related rules. According to government sources, WhatsApp has agreed to defer the rollout and Meta has met IT Ministry officials while preparing its response within the prescribed timeline.

Monsoon batters India

waterlogging, traffic congestion and tree fall incidents. A 63 year old man died after a tree crashed onto a shop in Kurla, the second fatal tree fall incident reported in the city within a week. The civic administration declared a holiday on Monday for all government, private and civic run schools and colleges because of an orange alert for heavy rain. Odisha placed all districts on alert as the approaching depression threatened heavy rainfall. The IMD issued a red warning for Sambalpur, Angul, Boudh, Sonepur and Kandhamal districts, while orange and yellow alerts covered the rest of the state. Fishermen have been advised to stay away from the sea until July 7 because of rough to very rough conditions. Neighbouring West Bengal is also expected to receive widespread rainfall as the weather system moves inland.

Kerala recorded widespread rainfall on Sunday. Orange alerts have been issued for Kannur and Kasaragod on July 6, and for Kozhikode, Kannur and Kasaragod on July 7, while yellow alerts remain in force for several northern districts. The Kerala State Disaster Management Authority urged residents living in landslide, mudslide and flash flood prone areas to move to safer places if instructed by officials. Emergency control rooms have been activated across the state.

In Himachal Pradesh, light to moderate rain continued across several districts, with the local weather office issuing an orange alert for heavy to very heavy rainfall over the next two days. Ghamroor received 84.2 mm of rain, followed by Dharamshala with 39.2 mm. Since July 1, the state has recorded 44.2 mm of rainfall against the normal 27.2 mm, an excess of 63 per cent. Thunderstorms and lightning were reported in parts of Kangra and nearby areas, while Bilaspur recorded the state's highest temperature at 36 degrees Celsius.

Delhi registered its warmest July day in two years, with the maximum temperature reaching 38.6 degrees Celsius despite afternoon showers. Chhatarpur recorded 49 mm of rainfall, causing waterlogging, while Gurugram received 35 mm. Rain was also reported in Mehrauli, Greater Noida, Najafgarh and Janakpuri. The IMD has issued an orange alert for Delhi on Monday and forecast moderate rain as the monsoon trough shifts towards northwest India.

In Haryana, rain inundated several parts of Gurugram, including Narsinghpur, Rajiv Chowk, AIT Chowk, Khandsa Road and old Gurugram, although officials said underpasses remained operational. Hot and humid conditions continued elsewhere in Haryana and Punjab. Sirsa recorded a maximum temperature of 40.8 degrees Celsius, while Bathinda touched 40.3 degrees Celsius. The IMD said the southwest monsoon is likely to cover the remaining parts of both states within the next three days.

In Uttar Pradesh, the first major monsoon showers exposed infrastructure concerns after part of a road linking the Ganga Expressway with the Kanpur Lucknow National Highway caved in at Unnao. Muzaffarnagar received 9 mm of rain, while Prayagraj and Varanasi airport recorded 8.8 mm each. Lucknow remained hot and humid with a maximum temperature of 39 degrees Celsius. More rain, thunderstorms and lightning are expected over the next 24 hours.

Jharkhand is also likely to receive light to moderate rain with thunderstorms, lightning and gusty winds over the next four days. Yellow alerts have been issued for all districts from July 6 to 9, with heavy rainfall expected in several western and northeastern districts on different days.

Baruipur minor

leaving home to buy food, was found floating in a pond near Surjyapur Haat under Dhapdhapi II Gram Panchayat. Her family members and neighbours alleged that she had been abducted, gang-raped by local youths, strangled, and her body dumped in the water.

As news of the incident spread, thousands of residents poured onto the streets demanding immediate action. The victim's family and local residents initially refused to allow police to remove the body, alleging that the perpetrators were yet to be arrested.

The agitation soon turned violent after an enraged mob apprehended a local youth, identified as Indrajit Tanti (26), on suspicion of being involved in the crime. Tanti was beaten to death before police could rescue him.

Protesters blocked the Baruipur-Joynagar Road and the railway tracks on the Sealdah-Namkhana section, disrupting train services for more than five hours. Tyres were set ablaze on the tracks. When police attempted to recover the girl's body, they came under heavy stone-pelting, leaving several personnel injured. The mob also vandalised several police vehicles and set some of them on fire.

The situation was brought under control after heavy police reinforcements were rushed to the area and senior officers assured residents that those responsible would be brought to justice.

Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari spoke to the victim's grieving father over the phone, assuring him that the case would be tried in a fast-track court and that the government would seek capital punishment for the perpetrators.

Inspector General of Police (Presidency Range) Kankar Prasad Barui said several persons have been detained in connection with the attack on the police and that a massive manhunt had been launched to trace the remaining accused. He also said he had scheduled a meeting with the victim's family at Bhawani Bhavan on Tuesday to coordinate legal assistance.

The Trinamool Congress, meanwhile, targeted the BJP-led state government over the incident. In a post on its X handle, the party alleged that crimes against women continued to rise despite the BJP's promises on women's safety.

TMC chairperson Mamata Banerjee alleged that the administration had deployed police to prevent her from visiting Baruipur to meet the victim's family. Claiming that she had effectively been placed under surveillance, Banerjee said nearly 1,000 police personnel, including paramilitary forces, had been deployed in and around her residence and alleged that route marches were being conducted outside her house.

In a post on its official Facebook page, the party accused the BJP government of attempting to "choke the Opposition" by restricting the movement and democratic rights of Opposition leaders. It alleged that heavy police deployment outside the residences of Mamata and national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee amounted to "a deliberate and cowardly display of intimidation". There was no immediate response from the police or the state government to the allegation.

Abhishek alleged that the BJP had fostered "a climate where those accused of heinous crimes appear to believe they enjoy political protection". He claimed the Baruipur incident raised disturbing questions over whether political influence was overshadowing the pursuit of justice and criticised what he described as the absence of protests, public outrage and demands for accountability following the crime.

TMC leader Derek O'Brien also took to X, alleging that more than 10 police vehicles had been deliberately parked in the narrow lane outside party chairperson Mamata Banerjee's residence to prevent her from leaving for Baruipur to meet the victim's family. TMC MP Mahua Moitra and MLA Kunal Ghosh also made similar claims on their X account.

Hormuz disruption

priority consumers, raising concerns over India's energy security.

The ministry said the situation has improved since then. "The ongoing conflict in the Middle East that had resulted in the disruption of liquefied natural gas shipments through the Strait of Hormuz has been subject to a ceasefire, and negotiations are ongoing, as part of which, sea traffic through the Strait of Hormuz has been permitted to be resumed," the notification said.

It added that, in view of these developments, the government was "omitting" parts of the March 9 order that had prioritised the allocation of available gas supplies.

The gas supply restrictions were one

of three emergency measures introduced after energy supplies from the Gulf came under threat following US and Israeli strikes on Iran on February 28 and Tehran's retaliatory attacks, which effectively disrupted traffic through the strategic waterway.

The other two emergency measures, directing refiners to maximise LPG production by diverting feedstock from petrochemical units and restricting diesel sales to bulk consumers, had already been withdrawn after fuel supplies returned to normal.

India remains heavily dependent on imported energy. The country imports about 88 per cent of its crude oil requirements and nearly half of its natural gas demand. Around 40 to 45 per cent of crude oil imports and about 65 per cent of LNG supplies originate from West Asia, making the Strait of Hormuz a critical route for India's energy imports.

Although India managed to diversify crude oil purchases by sourcing supplies from other producing nations during the crisis, natural gas imports remained exposed because most LNG cargoes from Qatar pass through the Strait of Hormuz. The March order gave the government powers to direct sector-wise allocation and diversion of domestic gas, LNG and regasified LNG to ensure uninterrupted supplies to essential consumers. It guaranteed full supplies, based on the previous six months' average consumption, to piped natural gas households, compressed natural gas for transport, LPG production and pipeline operations.

Fertiliser plants were assured 70 per cent of their average gas requirement, while industrial consumers connected to the national gas grid and city gas distribution networks were guaranteed 80 per cent of their average consumption, subject to operational availability.

To meet these commitments, gas supplies to petrochemical plants and power stations could be reduced, while oil refiners were directed to cut gas consumption to about 65 per cent of their average use wherever operationally feasible.

The order also required state-run GAIL, working with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell, to pool and redistribute gas supplies, determine pooled prices for diverted gas and oversee revised allocation schedules. Gas producers, LNG importers, marketers, pipeline operators and city gas distributors were required to comply with the revised supply plan, with the emergency provisions taking precedence over existing commercial agreements.

Hormuz safely

The ministry said eight vessels are transporting 3.32 lakh tonnes of urea, four are carrying 2.57 lakh tonnes of DAP and three hold 1.11 lakh tonnes of sulphur, all scheduled to reach Indian ports on time. Five more vessels are expected, including one carrying 0.25 lakh tonnes of ammonia and another with 0.45 lakh tonnes of urea. Two additional urea vessels and one sulphur vessel are also being loaded.

The Centre said timely planning, coordination and continuous monitoring, along with diplomatic efforts to secure new suppliers, helped maintain uninterrupted fertilizer availability. Urea has been sourced from countries including Oman, Russia, Egypt and the Netherlands, while DAP and NPK cargoes have been arranged through the Red Sea from Russia, Morocco, Jordan, Saudi Arabia and others.

Union Minister for Chemicals and Fertilizers JP Nadda said the conflict disrupted global supply chains, raised fertilizer prices and increased transit time, but the government protected farmers through proactive steps. Natu-

ral gas supply to fertilizer plants has recovered from nearly 65 per cent to 100 per cent, allowing full operations.

During April to June of FY27, urea production reached 71.55 lakh tonnes against a target of 67.86 lakh tonnes. DAP output stood at 9.84 lakh tonne, NPK at 20.77 lakh tonne and SSP at 13.50 lakh tonne. India has secured 197.56 lakh tonnes of fertilizer against its annual requirement of 383.9 lakh tonnes. As of July 2, total fertilizer availability stood at 163.35 lakh tonnes, with the ministry saying adequate stocks and higher domestic production continue to support timely supplies nationwide.

MPOST

SIT suspects jewellery

Investigators have taken possession of key financial documents of the trust and are examining alleged discrepancies in audit records and financial transactions. Officials suspect that manipulation of donation amounts may have taken place during the counting process itself, making it difficult to determine the actual amount received and the extent of any possible embezzlement.

The SIT is also examining records related to jewellery donations worth several crores of rupees. Sources said audit documents do not contain detailed references to these valuables, prompting investigators to closely examine the trail of donated ornaments.

According to sources, the SIT has questioned all three chartered accountants associated with the trust and collected documents related to the audit process. Some of the queries raised by investigators reportedly remained unanswered and the accountants may be called again for further questioning.

The probe has also widened to include alleged irregularities in land transactions linked to the temple trust. Statements of several individuals have been recorded and documents seized as investigators attempt to piece together the larger financial picture surrounding the temple's affairs.

Meanwhile, police are trying to establish links between the eight accused already arrested in the donation theft case and several other individuals, including some bank employees and counting staff, who are suspected to have been in contact with the accused. Further action is likely after investigators gather additional evidence.

Six killed, one injured

The incident occurred at Chawl No 5 in Janta Nagar, behind Hanuman Mandir, in the Mandala locality at around 8.30 pm, they said.

As per preliminary information, two to three tenements forming part of the three-storey structure caved in, prompting a rescue operation by personnel from Mumbai Fire Brigade, police, BMC ward office and '108' ambulance services, the officials said.

A search and rescue operation is continuing to pull out a person feared trapped under the debris, officials said, adding that a team from the NDRF had also arrived at the scene.

Local BJP corporator Navnath Ban also said one more person is missing.

He said the structure collapsed onto an adjoining hut on the collector's land. The rescue operation is being hampered by heavy rains, he added.

AGENCIES

Uttarakhand CM flags off first batch of Kailash Mansarovar Yatra

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHAMPAWAT/PITHORAGARH:

Flagging off the first batch of the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra via the Lipulekh Pass from Tanakpur in Champawat on Sunday, Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami said the pilgrimage is a symbol of spiritual consciousness and national harmony.

Amidst chants of "Har-Har Mahadev", welcoming them by presenting Rudraksh rosaries and patkas (ceremonial scarves) dedicated to Lord Shiva, Dhami interacted with the pilgrims and wished them a safe and auspicious journey, officials said.

According to the officials, the first batch of 49 pilgrims, including a doctor, comprising 34 men and 15 women, had arrived in Tanakpur from Delhi on Saturday evening.

The annual Kailash Mansarovar Yatra taking place via two routes -- Lipulekh Pass in Uttarakhand and Nathu La in Sikkim -- holds religious significance to Hindus as well as Jains and Buddhists.

The pilgrimage to Mount Kailash and Mansarovar Lake in China's Tibet Autonomous Region resumed last year after a gap of nearly five years as part of efforts to normalise the relations between India and China.

Dhami remarked that it is only through the grace of Lord Bholenath that pilgrims get the opportunity to undertake this sacred journey.

Urging the pilgrims to strengthen the local economy by purchasing local handicrafts and products, Dhami noted that it connects people across the country with the rich culture, traditions, and local way of life of the border villages.

Earlier, upon their arrival in Tanakpur, the pilgrims were welcomed with the traditional Chholiya dance, a shower of flower petals, and garlands.

Manoj Kumar, Manager of the Sharda Tourist Rest House in Tanakpur, said that the first group consists of 49 pilgrims, including a doctor, comprising 34 men and 15 women. He mentioned that the group includes pilgrims from Andhra Pradesh, Delhi, Gujarat, Haryana, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Uttar Pradesh, and Uttarakhand.

Purushottam Khandelwal, a 68-year-old pilgrim from Rajasthan, is the oldest member of the group, while 21-year-old Harikrishna from Gujarat is the youngest.

The group of pilgrims will travel from Tanakpur and arrive at the base camp in Dharchula, Pithoragarh district, on Sunday evening and after an overnight stay, they will depart for the next halt, Gunji, on Monday morning.

The Yatra is being conducted via the Tanakpur route for the second consecutive year. This route is more accessible than the previous one.

Previously, pilgrims would travel from Delhi to Haldwani and then reach Dharchula via Almora and Pithoragarh.

mp
EDITORIAL
REGULATORY
QUESTIONS

WhatsApp's decision to introduce usernames marks one of the biggest changes to its identity model since the platform was launched. For years, a phone number has served as both the gateway to the service and the primary means of establishing authenticity. The proposed feature promises a welcome privacy upgrade by allowing users to interact without disclosing their mobile numbers, particularly in public groups, marketplaces and conversations with strangers. At a time when concerns over personal data are growing, reducing the need to expose phone numbers appears sensible. Yet identity on digital platforms is a delicate balance between privacy and trust. While the former empowers users, the latter enables accountability. WhatsApp's challenge is to ensure that protecting one does not inadvertently weaken the other.

The concerns raised by cybersecurity experts are therefore neither alarmist nor unfounded. Every major digital platform that has adopted usernames has wrestled with impersonation, typo-squatting and fraudulent lookalike accounts. Criminals thrive in environments where a slight alteration of a name can deceive unsuspecting users. India already battles an epidemic of phishing, investment scams, fake customer-care accounts and so-called digital arrest frauds. Introducing usernames could hand fraudsters another avenue if safeguards prove inadequate. Meta argues that usernames will not be searchable, that additional verification keys will be available and that contextual warnings will alert recipients to unfamiliar contacts. These are valuable protections, but they are largely reactive. The real test will lie in whether impersonation attempts can be prevented before victims receive deceptive messages rather than merely detected afterwards. Equally important is ensuring that ordinary citizens and small businesses enjoy the same degree of protection as public figures and verified accounts.

The government's intervention reflects the growing tendency of regulators to scrutinise technological changes before they reach consumers. Its concerns about fraud deserve serious consideration because cybercrime has become a major economic and law enforcement challenge. However, regulation must also remain firmly anchored in law and proportionality. Asking technology companies to explain risk assessments and mitigation strategies is reasonable, particularly when billions of users could be affected. Attempting to exercise prior approval over product design without a clear statutory basis is a far more contentious proposition. Innovation cannot flourish if every new feature becomes subject to uncertain executive discretion, just as consumer protection cannot succeed if platforms are left entirely to police themselves. The appropriate framework lies somewhere between unrestricted technological experimentation and pre-emptive governmental veto. Transparent consultation, evidence-based regulation and clearly defined legal powers are essential if public confidence is to be maintained.

Ultimately, the debate extends far beyond WhatsApp. It reflects a broader question confronting every digital society: how should online identities evolve in an age where privacy, convenience and security increasingly compete with one another? Phone numbers are no longer ideal identifiers because they expose personal information and can themselves become instruments of fraud. Usernames offer an alternative that is potentially more private but only if supported by robust verification, intelligent fraud detection and swift mechanisms to report and remove impersonators. Success will not be measured by how elegantly the feature is designed, but by whether users feel safer after adopting it. Technology companies must recognise that trust is earned through transparency and consistent enforcement, while governments must ensure that oversight encourages safer innovation rather than stifling it. If both sides approach the issue with restraint and responsibility, the username could become a genuine privacy enhancement instead of the next frontier for digital deception.

ENDURING
IDEALS



NARENDRA MODI

THE WRITER IS THE
PRIME MINISTER
OF INDIA

Industry, education
and national
unity were, for
Dr Mookerjee,
inseparable
pillars of a
strong and self-
reliant India

BUDDHA'S
AMBASSADOR



ANIRBAN GANGULY

THE WRITER IS
A MEMBER OF
THE NATIONAL
EXECUTIVE
COMMITTEE (NEC),
BJP, AND THE
CHAIRMAN OF DR
SYAMA PRASAD
MOOKERJEE
RESEARCH
FOUNDATION

Dr Syama Prasad
Mookerjee
facilitated the
1949 return of
Sariputta and
Mahamogallana's
sacred relics from
London's Victoria
and Albert
Museum

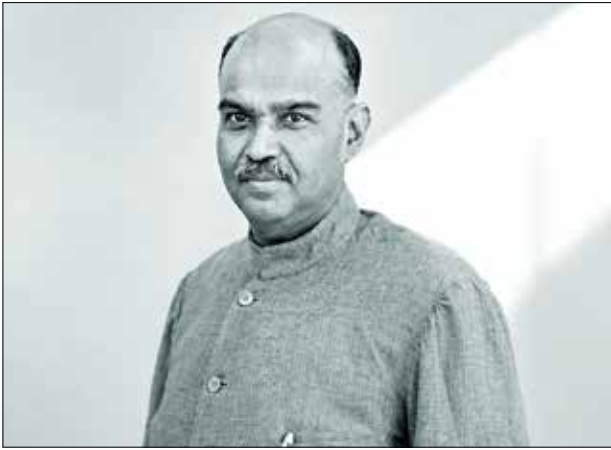
A Life Dedicated to the Nation

Scholar, statesman and nationalist, Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee's vision for a united, self-reliant India continues inspiring generations across the nation

Today, 6th July, is a special day for countless people who cherish the ideals of nationalism and selfless service. We commemorate the 125th birth anniversary of Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee, whose life remains a timeless example of courage and unwavering commitment to Maa Bharti. Few leaders in modern India embodied the seamless confluence of intellect, public service and moral conviction as profoundly as Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee.

The young Syama Prasad was born into circumstances that could easily have assured him a protected and comfortable life. His father, Sir Ashutosh Mookerjee, was among the foremost educationists and intellectuals of his age. Yet, while destiny placed before him a path of privilege, his conscience led him towards one of sacrifice and national service. He was convinced that he could not remain a mute spectator to the turbulence of his times, be it fighting colonialism, communalism, humanitarian challenges and more. Along this journey, he endured profound personal tragedies, including the loss of an infant child and, later, his wife. Yet, these tragedies only deepened his resolve and strengthened his unwavering commitment to serve.

If there was one ideal that defined Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee's public life above all else, it was the indivisibility of India. He stood firm during the upheaval of Partition to ensure that West Bengal remained an integral part of India. A few years later, that very conviction drew him to Jammu and Kashmir. Imprisonment did not deter him, and isolation did not diminish him. His life came to an abrupt end in detention, far from the countless people whose cause he had made



As India marks the 125th birth anniversary of Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee, his contributions remain as relevant as ever

his own. There are moments in history when an individual's final sacrifice transcends politics and enters the realm of national memory. Dr Mookerjee's last journey remains one such moment. Acharya Vinoba Bhave said that Dr Mookerjee sacrificed himself for a cause in which he had faith. Years later, the revocation of Articles 370 and 35(A) in 2019 was the most fitting tribute to his martyrdom.

Dr Mookerjee put India First and Indian values first. And he did it by building institutions and nurturing systems that defied conventional mindsets of those times. He became the youngest Vice Chancellor of the University of Calcutta. In his unique style, he brought positive changes that were patriotic and futuristic. Addressing a conference of educators, Dr Mookerjee put it wonderfully when he said, "It is incorrect to look upon educational institutions as factories to produce potential clerks and low-paid staff. We have to turn out students who are capable of providing leadership to our self-governing institutions,

such as municipal corporations, provincial and central legislatures and also of directing the affairs in various fields of life such as financial, commercial and industrial ones."

Under his leadership, Calcutta University undertook unique efforts such as improving library infrastructure, boosting research in sciences, encouraging the study of artefacts and establishing courses in agriculture, to name a few. He drew attention to areas such as sports, teacher training and student welfare. To instil a sense of pride among students and alumni, he began a practice of marking 24th January as the foundation day of the University. He requested none other than Gurudev Tagore to compose a song for the University.

Yet another example of this spirit can be seen in the later part of his life, when he decided to form the Bharatiya Jana Sangh. At a time when the Congress Party was omnipresent, he felt that there was all the more reason for an alternative voice to speak up for India's progress while staying attached to our

cultural roots. It was perhaps fitting that the party's symbol was the Diya, the earthen lamp. A single lamp may appear modest, yet it possesses the power to dispel darkness far beyond itself. It is exactly what the Jana Sangh did both during the years it was active and beyond.

Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee's tenure as India's first Minister for Industry and Supply reveals a statesman whose conception of development was remarkably comprehensive and humane. He viewed industry as a means of restoring dignity, opportunity and confidence to a newly independent nation. He respected wealth creation and value addition. While laying the foundations of modern industrial India through pioneering initiatives such as the Damodar Valley Corporation, the Sindri Fertiliser Plant and a robust industrial policy, he simultaneously ensured that India's traditional strengths were not neglected. Handlooms, cottage industries, artisans and textile workers found in him an equally committed champion.

Here, I would like to share a personal experience. The Sindri plant, which Dr Mookerjee worked to establish with a clear vision of self-reliance, was ignored by those who ran the nation for several decades. I feel honoured that our Government had the opportunity to contribute to its revival. It was indeed among the most special moments to have been there for that programme.

India's civilisational tradition has long celebrated dialogue and discussions. Dr Mookerjee embodied this democratic spirit. He joined Pandit Nehru's Cabinet, believing that the task of nation-building in the early years transcended political differences. He served with sincerity and a constructive spirit. But when he felt that questions of national impor-

ance demanded a different course, he relinquished office with dignity and devoted himself wholeheartedly to the political work he believed the nation required.

75 years ago, Pandit Nehru brought the First Amendment, which was a direct assault on free speech. Dr Mookerjee was among its staunchest critics. He understood fully what the Congress was capable of doing. And he was proven right. Those who brought the First Amendment 75 years ago imposed the Emergency in 1975 and, 50 years ago, brought in the 42nd Amendment Act, which again struck at the core of liberal democratic values.

Dr Mookerjee also stood out for his humanitarian efforts. When the most tragic famine struck Bengal in 1943, Dr Mookerjee immersed himself in serving those affected. He ensured that several canteens and relief centres were opened to feed people. On one hand, he was deeply shaken by the plight of his people, while on the other, he was repulsed by the insensitivity of the colonial rulers. He even wrote a book, Panchasher Manwantar, in which he expressed his angst. When a super cyclone hit Medinipur in 1942, his efforts to restore normalcy were widely lauded.

Speaking at a college in Kolkata, Dr Mookerjee urged the youth, "Whatever work you undertake, do it seriously, thoroughly and well; never leave it half-done or undone, never feel yourself satisfied unless and until you have given it your very best." As India advances towards the goal of a Viksit Bharat, the finest tribute we can pay him is to strive every day to build the strong, united, self-confident and compassionate India that he so deeply believed in. And knowing today's youth, I am certain they will rise to the occasion and do exactly that.

Messenger of the Dhamma

Beyond politics, Dr Mookerjee emerged as independent India's foremost ambassador of Buddhism, reconnecting ancient civilisational bonds across Asia through culture

As we commemorate the 125th birth anniversary of Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee and discuss and celebrate his multifaceted life and contributions there is one dimension of his life which makes him stand apart from many others of his era and generation. As the messenger and ambassador of Buddha and Buddhism, Syama Prasad attracts our attention. A unique blend, perhaps in that epoch, a rarity in our times.

Just as he never severed his connection and link with education, Syama Prasad, the president of the Hindu Mahasabha, member of the Constituent Assembly, the creator of West Bengal, free India's first industry minister, the founder president of Bharatiya Jana Sangh, member of the first Lok Sabha, the undecclared Leader of Opposition, the valiant defender of India's unity and integrity, grew into becoming one of India's finest cultural and civilizational ambassador in the early years after independence. He had a lifelong interest in and connection with India's Buddhist legacy and heritage.

On becoming president of the Maha Bodhi Society of India, Syama Prasad emerged as one of the finest spokespersons and representatives of civilizational India's Buddhist legacy and inheritance. Between 1942 and 1953, while being seen, accepted and followed as one of modern India's most towering Hindu leaders, Syama Prasad was also recognised as one of the most energetic ambassadors of Buddha and of Buddhism, from the land of its origin. There was no contradiction in his persona and psyche between his Hindu persona and his championing of India's Buddhist legacy.

D Valisinha, general secretary of the Maha Bodhi Society during Syama Prasad's tenure, writes that he was "elected unanimously with universal approbation" and that he "proved to be the most energetic, resourceful and hardworking President we ever had..."

The Maha Bodhi Society of India, in those days, was a nodal institution and movement and the presidency of that body came with a role and responsibility that resonated across the Buddhist world.

By the time he became president of the Maha Bodhi Society, Syama Prasad had already made a deep impression in the political and educational firmament of India. He



Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee was the architect of India's early Buddhist diplomacy and civilisational renaissance across Asia

had earned wide recognition for his erudition, sagacity and for his pragmatist nationalist approach and politics. His father, Asutosh Mookerjee, before him, had contributed immensely to rekindling study and research in India's Buddhist heritage and legacy. Asutosh initiated the Pali department in the Calcutta University in the early 1900s and, as Vice Chancellor, encouraged and patronised scholars in the study and research of civilizational India's Buddhist heritage.

Asutosh Mookerjee was invited to become president of the Maha Bodhi Society and, in his lifetime, among other things, became one of India's most visible symbols of her rekindled interest in her Buddhist legacy. For his contribution to Buddhism in modern times, writes Dinesh Chandra Sen, legendary litterateur and scholar of Bengali language and literature, Asutosh Mookerjee was conferred the title of "Sambuddhagama Chakravarty", the one great soul who treads the path of the Buddha, by the Buddhist sangha of Sri Lanka, more specifically by the influential and then dominant Amarapura Nikaya.

A lot of that activism and work had flowed into Syama Prasad. While doing his Master's in Ben-

gali language and literature, Syama Prasad and opted for a paper on Sinhalese language. Fascinated by languages, he understood early that they could act as active civilizational bridges.

Later as the youngest Vice Chancellor of the Calcutta University, Syama Prasad encouraged and supported Buddhist studies and promoted the study of Pali. It is symbolic that Syama Prasad Mookerjee's finest political and most accomplished political heir, his manasputra, Narendra Modi, declared Pali as a classical language, conferring on it the exalted status of a living civilizational heritage of India.

In his activism and outreach through and for India's Buddhist legacy, Modi comes across as fulfilling and amplifying Syama Prasad's aspirations. As Syama Prasad, Modi too blends his political and statesman persona with his active interest and dynamic drive in disseminating India's Buddhist legacy. He deeply understands, just as Syama Prasad did in his time, the unique strength and power of India's Buddhist legacy in reforging civilizational partnerships and bonds.

Eminent historian Niharjan Ray, one of India's greatest Buddhist scholars, Beni Madhav Barua, who

taught Buddhist studies and Pali in Calcutta University, have spoken of Syama Prasad's munificent support in their studies and research on Buddhism.

Syama Prasad saw through and presided over several historic events that symbolized a free India aspiring to recover her civilizational and cultural legacy. It was at Syama Prasad's behest and active interest that the sacred Relics of Buddha's two chief disciples, Mahamogallana and Sariputta were repatriated to India from the Victoria and Albert Museum in London in January 1949, after 100 years. The mind is naturally drawn to our times, when at the behest and intervention of PM Modi, the sacred Piprahwa Gem Relics, about to be auctioned in a foreign land to a foreign entity, were repatriated to India after 127 years.

It was at Syama Prasad Mookerjee's initiative that the Relics of Mahamogallana and Sariputta were enshrined at the Chetiyagiri Vihara in Sanchi, which was inaugurated, through a grand ceremony in November 1952, next to the iconic Sanchi Stupa. Over 50,000 people attended that deeply symbolic event, which signified a new cultural awakening in free India.

As president of the Maha Bodhi Society, Syama Prasad conceived and organised the first-ever International Buddhist Cultural Conference (IBCC) in India in Sanchi in November-December 1952. It was to be his last major public event. The IBCC was held under the presidency of Dr S Radhakrishnan, then Vice President of India, over 2000 delegates participated in it, including distinguished visitors, scholars and monks from various parts of the world.

Pandit Nehru, Prime Minister of Burma, U Nu, Home Minister of Sri Lanka A Ratnayake, Venerable Kushak Bakula Rinpoche of Ladakh, Acharya Narendra Deva, then Vice Chancellor of Banaras Hindu University, historian Radha Kumud Mookerjee, Bhikkhu Jagadish Kashyap, among a host of others, were present. Ambassadors and representatives of Buddhist countries participated in the IBCC. It was the first such Buddhist mega event in independent India.

Dr Mookerjee's role as India's unofficial cultural ambassador received international recognition. He led "Dhamma Yatras", with Relics of Arhants Mahamogallana and Sariputta, to Southeast Asian coun-

tries such as Burma, Cambodia, Thailand and Vietnam. Addressing massive crowds in these countries, Dr Mookerjee spoke of Buddha's message and of India's cultural and spiritual link with these countries.

In October 1952, Dr Mookerjee visited Cambodia, with the sacred Relics, at the invitation of King Norodom Sihanouk and the Government of Cambodia. A sea of humanity awaited him, as the flight from Bangkok hovered over and landed in Phnom Penh. Over a million people lined up the route from the airport to the city. Dr Mookerjee addressed over half a million people in the city's main square on Lord Buddha's message and the cultural ties that bound India and Buddhist countries.

When he led the delegation to Myanmar, with the Relics, and later ensured that a portion of it was given as a permanent loan from the people and Government of India to the people of Myanmar, an effusive Prime Minister U Nu, himself a distinguished Buddhist scholar, told Dr Mookerjee, "You do not know how great a service you rendered to my country... Your visit with the Relics brought about a wonderful change in my people. They have found their soul."

Today, when PM Modi has led the resumption of these "Relics Dhamma Yatras" across the world, the mind flies back to that era when Syama Prasad resumed these yatras, after a millennium-long hiatus, in free India. Millions of people, having a glimpse of the sacred Relics from Thailand to Vietnam, from Cambodia to Mongolia, from Ladakh to Sri Lanka, today, display an earnest aspiration to revivify and rekindle the special civilizational bond between India and these countries and civilisations, also nurtured and shaped by Lord Buddha's message.

One of Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee's last communications, in April 1953, a few weeks before his 45-day detention in Kashmir that led to his death, was to the Prime Minister of Sri Lanka, D Senanayake, expressing his hope to lead a delegation with the Sanchi Relics to Lanka in the winter of 1953. That was to never be. As we celebrate his many lives and legacy, let us also recall and commemorate Syama Prasad Mookerjee, as Bhagavan Buddha's ambassador, as one of free India's earliest and most radiant cultural and civilizational messengers.

Views expressed are personal

EFFORTS TO CURB ILLEGAL MINING

Implement zero coal leakage plan, HM Shah tells officials

HM chairs high-level review meeting on illegal coal mining and coal theft

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Union Home minister Amit Shah chaired a high-level review meeting on illegal coal mining and coal theft in Dhanbad and adjoining areas, directing authorities to implement a “zero coal leakage plan” to crack down on illegal mining and unauthorised transportation of coal.

Union Coal and Mines minister G. Kishan Reddy was also present during the meeting, which was also attended by the Union Home secretary, Coal secretary and senior officials of the Ministry of Coal, CISF, Coal India Limited and Bharat Coking Coal Limited (BCL).

Expressing concern over the continuing menace of illegal mining and coal theft, Shah instructed the administrative machinery to adopt a zero-tolerance approach and strengthen enforcement measures to plug all leakages in the coal supply chain.

Officials presented a progress report on steps taken since the previous review meeting held in October 2025. They informed the Home minis-

HIGHLIGHTS

» Union Coal and Mines minister G. Kishan Reddy was also present during the meeting, which was also attended by the Union Home secretary, Coal secretary and senior officials of the Ministry of Coal, CISF, Coal India Limited and Bharat Coking Coal Limited

» Shah expressed concern over the continuing menace of illegal mining and coal theft

» He instructed the administrative machinery to adopt a zero-tolerance approach and strengthen enforcement measures to plug all leakages in the coal



FILE PIC

supply chain

» While appreciating the measures taken so far, Shah directed all agencies to intensify action within the legal framework and asked the Ministry of Coal to regularly review enforcement efforts

» He also stressed the need for close coordination with Goods and Services Tax (GST) authorities to verify e-way bills and curb the illegal transport and sale of coal

high-level review in December 2025, the Union Home secretary had constituted a Coal Sector Coordination Committee to oversee enforcement and improve coordination among various agencies involved in tackling illegal mining.

Shah directed all agencies to intensify action within the legal framework and asked the Ministry of Coal to regularly review enforcement efforts. He also stressed the need for close coordination with GST authorities to verify e-way bills and sale of coal. The Home minister further directed the Ministry of Home Affairs to treat the coal sector as a priority for the deployment of CISF personnel. He asked the force to deploy Quick Response Teams (QRTs) and establish a multi-layered security system in vulnerable mining areas to strengthen surveillance and enforcement. Shah also advocated the use of advanced technologies, including high-resolution cameras linked to Integrated Command and Control Centres, to improve intelligence gathering, identify illegal mining hotspots and facilitate prompt action against offenders.

and seizures of illegally mined coal, machinery and vehicles used in such activities, besides initiating legal action against offenders.

The meeting was also informed that, following a

Saini pays tribute to Mookerjee

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday said the sacrifice of Bharatiya Jana Sangh founder Syama Prasad Mookerjee strengthened the unity and integrity of the country and his vision was realised with the abrogation of Article 370 in Jammu and Kashmir.

Addressing a function in Pathankot, Punjab, to mark Mookerjee’s 125th birth anniversary, Saini said Mookerjee opposed the permit system for entering Jammu and Kashmir



and gave the slogan, “Ek desh mein do vidhan, do pradhan aur do nishan nahin challenge.”

He added that the BJP-led central government fulfilled

Mookerjee’s dream by revoking Article 370 in August 2019.

Mookerjee expressed serious disagreement with the Liaquat Ali Khan-Jawahar Lal Nehru pact, leading to his resignation from the Union Cabinet. Through this decision, he proved that the nation was more important to him than any position, Saini said. Mookerjee resigned from the Cabinet on April 8, 1950, over disagreements with PM Nehru over a pact with Pakistani PM Liaquat Ali Khan.

MPOST

CUE TAKEN FROM BOLLYWOOD THRILLER DRISHYAM

Agra: Woman kills husband, buries body beneath bathroom floor

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AGRA: In a chilling case that bears similarities to the plot of the film Drishyam, a woman in Agra allegedly killed her husband, buried his body beneath the bathroom floor and covered it with a fresh layer of cement and tiles to conceal the crime for nearly one-and-a-half months.

The accused, identified as Ruby, was arrested after she confessed to killing her husband Surendra, 44, in Sikandra’s Dhortora area. Police said the woman had been planning the murder for several days as she was allegedly fed up with her husband’s alcoholism, violent behaviour

and frequent domestic disputes.

According to investigators, Surendra had recently quit his job as a delivery agent and spent most of his time drinking. Ruby told police that he regularly assaulted her for money and had also begun misbehaving with their daughters, prompting her to plan his murder. Police said Ruby mixed more than 20 sleeping pills into a bowl of kheer on the night of May 17 after Surendra returned home, consumed alcohol and ate meat. Since he was fond of sweets, he ate the kheer and soon fell unconscious.

In her statement to police, Ruby said she woke up around 3 am and checked whether her

The floor was covered with a fresh layer of cement and tiles to conceal the crime for nearly one-and-a-half months

husband was breathing. After confirming that he was dead, she sent her mother-in-law and two daughters away the next morning on the pretext that Surendra had left home after a dispute.

Investigators said Ruby had already arranged construction

debris after noticing renovation work at a neighbouring house. She dug up the bathroom floor with a shovel, dragged the body inside and buried it in the pit. She also allegedly poured salt over the body in an attempt to hasten decomposition.

She then filled the pit with debris, levelled the floor and later purchased cement, sand and other materials herself. On May 19, she hired two labourers, who were unaware of the crime, to lay a new floor and install fresh tiles in the bathroom for Rs 500.

To avoid suspicion, Ruby filed a missing person’s complaint for her husband at Prachi Tower police outpost on May

26 and repeatedly claimed that Surendra had left home with Rs 3,000. Police visited the house during the search and checked CCTV footage, while Ruby allegedly broke down in tears whenever investigators arrived.

The crime came to light on Wednesday when police reached the house for verification in connection with an old truck theft case registered against Surendra in 2017. During questioning, Ruby appeared nervous and feared that someone had informed police about the murder.

On Friday, she called her brother-in-law Anil and confessed that she had killed Surendra. Anil immediately informed

the police. A police team then dug up the bathroom floor and recovered Surendra’s skeletal remains. Ruby was taken into custody and charged with murder and destruction of evidence.

Police also questioned the labourers who had laid the bathroom floor, suspecting that others might have been involved. However, the workers told investigators that they had no knowledge that a body was buried beneath the floor and were later let off after questioning.

Investigators said Ruby admitted during interrogation that she had watched films and web series and drew inspiration from crime plots while planning the murder.

MP: Hindu members included in Waqf Board

BHOPAL: Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav on Sunday reorganised the state Waqf Board, incorporating two Hindu members, officials said. They claimed that this new board, formed under the Waqf (Amendment) Act, 2025, is the first state-level Waqf Board in the country to have Hindu members.

The official said a gazette notification has been issued, appointing Sanwar Patel as the chairman of the ten-member Madhya Pradesh Waqf Board. Manoj Malpani and Animesh Bhargava have been included as Hindu members on this board.

“Madhya Pradesh has become the first state in the country to reorganise the Waqf Board under the new Act,” the official said.

He said that the state government, exercising the powers conferred by Section 13(1) of the Waqf Act, 1995 (amended in 2025), has constituted the Waqf Board as provided in Section 14 of the Act.

Nation Briefs

NFR: RPF RECOVERS CONTRABAND, VALUABLES WORTH RS 43L IN 6 DAYS

MALIGAON: The Railway Protection Force (RPF) of Northeast Frontier Railway (NFR) conducted 36 operations across its jurisdiction between June 25 and 30, 2026, cracking down on crime and unlawful activities at railway stations and aboard trains. The drives led to the seizure of 83.984 kg of ganja worth about Rs 41.99 lakh, 343 bottles and one can of illicit liquor/beer valued at over Rs 39,000, seven mobile phones worth more than Rs 1.12 lakh, illegal railway tickets worth over Rs 7,000 and cash exceeding Rs 35,000. The total value of recoveries exceeded Rs 43.92 lakh. The RPF also arrested 17 persons involved in offences including narcotics trafficking, ticket touting, theft, stone-pelting and other violations.

ECRWVO ORGANISES VAN MAHOTSAV

HAJIPUR: The East Central Railway Women’s Welfare Organisation (ECRWVO) organised a Van Mahotsav programme at Aarekh Udyan in the Patliputra Rail Campus on July 4 to promote environmental awareness among children. The event was held under the leadership of ECRWVO president Sunita Singh, during which children participated in a tree plantation drive. They were also educated about the importance of plants and environmental conservation. As a token of encouragement, each child was presented with a potted plant. The programme was attended by ECRWVO vice-president Ranjana Kumar, secretary Manisha Sinha, and other members.

DAY 16 OF CJP PROTEST

Wangchuk loses 6 kg as fast enters 8th day

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Cockroach Janta Party’s (CJP) protest at the Jantar Mantar here, demanding Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan’s resignation and government accountability over alleged examination irregularities, entered its 16th day on Sunday, while it was the eighth day of an indefinite hunger strike announced by climate activist Sonam Wangchuk, who has lost around six kg since beginning the fast.

According to a health bulletin issued by doctors, Wangchuk’s blood pressure was recorded at 112/70 mm Hg in the lying-down position, heart rate at 72 beats per minute and blood sugar at 67 mg/dL. The bulletin said his hydration is fair, he is mentally alert and his weight has dropped to 60.95 kg, accounting for a loss of around six kg in seven days.

The CJP continued to press for Pradhan’s resignation, alleging



Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk looks on, as people hold photos of NEET aspirant Ria, who allegedly died by suicide in Dehradun, during a hunger strike by CJP, at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi, Sunday

PTI

ing that repeated examination irregularities and paper leaks have devastated the lives of students and their families.

In a post on X, CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke said the parents of NEET aspirant Riya Kumari Thapa, who the outfit claims died after the alleged paper leak shattered her dreams, visited the protest site on Sunday.

Dipke said Thapa’s father,

an Army veteran, joined the protest with the appeal that no other family should have to endure the loss that his family has suffered and urged the Centre to ensure that such incidents are not repeated.

In another post, the CJP said it stands firmly with Thapa’s parents in their grief and fight against what it described as a corrupt system that failed

their daughter.

The NEET held on May 3, was cancelled amid allegations of paper leak. A re-test was held on June 21.

Meanwhile, the Samyukta Kisan Morcha (SKM), which had earlier extended support to the CJP agitation, is now scheduled to send a delegation to the Jantar Mantar on July 7. The farmers’ body had initially said in its letter to the CJP that its delegation would visit the protest site on Sunday.

The SKM has expressed solidarity with the students and youngsters participating in the agitation, saying every student has the right to a transparent, fair and credible examination system and that ensuring accountability is the government’s responsibility.

Several members of the Left-affiliated All India Students’ Association (AISA) also continued their indefinite hunger strike on a separate stage at the protest site.

Punjab & Haryana reel under sultry weather

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Sirsa in Haryana and Bathinda in Punjab on Sunday reeled under the hot weather, recording day temperatures over 40 degrees Celsius as sultry weather prevailed at several places in the two states.

Sirsa recorded a maximum temperature of 40.8 degrees Celsius while Bathinda registered a high of 40.3 degrees Celsius, the met said, adding that Ambala, Hisar, and Fatehabad also experienced the hot weather, recording respective maximums of 39.2 degrees, 38.9 degrees and 36.8 degrees Celsius.

Karnal recorded a high of 34.8 degrees Celsius.

Chandigarh -- the common capital of the two states -- with the maximum temperature of 37.9 degrees Celsius, also witnessed sultry weather.

In Punjab, Patiala recorded a maximum of 37.2 degrees Celsius while Amritsar registered a high of 35.9 degrees Celsius.

Gurdaspur recorded a high of 36 degrees Celsius while Mohali recorded a maximum of 37.1 degrees Celsius.

According to the met, the southwest monsoon had advanced into parts of Haryana and Punjab on July 1, with Gurugram and Karnal in Haryana and Ferozepur in Punjab receiving rainfall on Sunday.

The department issued a forecast on Sunday that conditions are favourable for further advance of the southwest monsoon into the remaining parts of Haryana and Punjab in the next three days.



SIT PROBE LIKELY AMONG AGENDA

Will Champat Rai’s fate be decided in Ram temple trust meeting today?

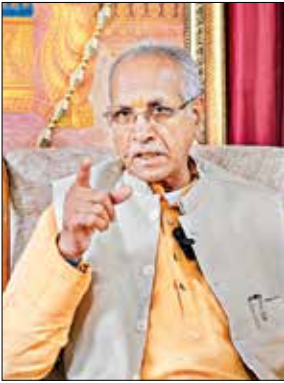
OUR CORRESPONDENT

AYODHYA: The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust will hold a crucial meeting on Monday amid ongoing investigations into the alleged embezzlement of donations, with the fate of the resignations submitted by the Trust’s general secretary Champat Rai and trustee Anil Mishra expected to dominate the agenda, Trust sources told news agency.

The meeting, scheduled to be held at Mani Ram Chhawni -- the monastery of Trust president Nritya Gopal Das -- will take place for the first time since the controversy broke out.

Trust treasurer Govind Dev Giri has asked all regular and ex-officio members to attend the deliberations.

Ahead of the meeting, Giri distanced himself from the controversy, saying he had no role in the daily donation



Champat Rai

process. He said that all audit reports were “safe” and any authorised person can look into them.

Sources in Ayodhya said the possibility of 89-year-old Das attending the meeting is high following his discharge from the hospital.

Hospital sources in Lucknow told a news agency that Das was admitted here on June

Highlights

- » Trust treasurer Govind Dev Giri has asked all regular and ex-officio members to attend the deliberations
- » Sources in Ayodhya said the possibility of 89-year-old Das attending the meeting is high following his discharge from the hospital

29 with a urinary tract infection and breathing difficulties, and was discharged on Friday.

Sources told the news agency that senior trustee K Parasaran, who cannot travel due to age-related health issues, may participate in the meeting via video conference.

According to sources, the Trust is likely to discuss the resignations of Champat

Rai and Anil Mishra, both of whom stepped down after being linked to the donation theft row.

If their resignations are accepted, the meeting is also likely to consider plans for a new administrative structure for the Trust’s operations. The role of special invitee Gopal Rao is also expected to be discussed, sources said.

Additionally, the meeting is likely to include a briefing on the interim findings of the Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing the alleged embezzlement case, and will likely address the future management framework for the Ram temple.

Sources said that an unaudited income and expenditure statement, balance sheet, and other financial details for the 2025-26 fiscal year will be presented for approval.

Furthermore, discussions regarding the appointment of a chief executive officer to

oversee the management of the Ram temple are expected to take place during the meeting, sources told the news agency.

Currently, the Trust comprises 11 regular members, including president Nritya Gopal Das, Vasudevanand Saraswati, Vishwaprasannathir, Parmanand Giri, treasurer Govind Dev Giri, Krishna Mohan, Dinendra Das, and K Parasaran.

With the resignations of Champat Rai and Anil Mishra, and the recent death of trustee Bimlendra Mohan Pratap Mishra, the Trust currently lacks a vice president to preside over meetings in the president’s absence, sources say.

The ex-officio members include Union government secretary Prashant Lekhande, Uttar Pradesh government secretary Sanjay Prasad, Ayodhya District Magistrate Shashank Tripathi and former Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister Nripendra Mishra.

‘Those looting Hindus are in power’

Uddhav launches Ram Raksha agitation, targets B7P

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray on Sunday launched his “Ram Raksha” agitation over the alleged donation embezzlement at the Ayodhya Ram temple and said those looting Hindus are in power, seeking to corner the ruling BJP over Hindutva.

Addressing a rally outside the Hanuman temple in Dadar in central Mumbai, where he recited “Hanuman Stotra”, “Hanuman Chalisa” and “Ram Raksha Stotra”, Thackeray demanded an impartial probe into the matter.

“If anyone loots a temple by misusing Hindutva, then Hindus will not spare them,” he said.

Thackeray also gave a call for a “BJP-mukht Ram”, saying Lord Ram belongs to everyone.

The BJP hit back at Thackeray, with Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis saying he was glad that the Sena (UBT) chief had “finally remembered Ram” after allegedly abandoning the path shown by the Lord.

Speaking to reporters in Gadchiroli on the sidelines of a programme, Fadnavis said, “Our



Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray launches Ram Raksha agitation over the alleged donation embezzlement at the Ayodhya Ram temple during a rally, in Mumbai, Sunday

PTI

only expectation was that he should remember Ram. He had abandoned Ram’s path. That’s why his party declined. If he walks the path of Ram, it will be good for him. Not just today, I expect that he will recite ‘Ram Raksha’ every day.”

Ever since Thackeray parted ways with the BJP in 2019 and aligned with the Congress, his former ally has repeatedly accused him of abandoning Hindutva. This was also one of the reasons that current Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde had cited when he revolted against Thackeray

in 2022 and split the Shiv Sena. In his address, Thackeray alleged, “In the last 12 years, we thought our ‘bhagwa’ (saffron) government was in power. Atalji (BJP stalwart and former prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee) had said that now Hindus would not get beaten up. It is unfortunate that the people in power are looting Hindus.”

Wearing a saffron kurta, Thackeray said a robber cannot be asked to probe the robbery committed by him. It has to be done impartially or else a clean chit will be given to everyone, he said.

BJP leaders says all allies united, NDA to focus on repeating 2017 UP poll win



LUCKNOW: The BJP will work with its allies to repeat the performance of the 2017 Assembly polls on the strength of the work done in the state, party leaders said after a meeting with BJP president Nitin Nabin on Sunday.

Later in a meeting with NDA allies, Nabin discussed measures to strengthen the alliance but no discussion was held on seat-sharing, party sources said.

“The Bharatiya Janata Party is capable of fighting elections. We will ensure that all NDA constituents continue to work together to make Uttar Pradesh an ‘Uttam Pradesh,’” the BJP chief told reporters after meet-

ing BJP allies at the Taj Hotel.

Nabin, who is on a two-day visit to Lucknow, started his day with a meeting over tea with former BJP presidents of the state. They discussed the 2027 Assembly election strategy, sources said.

Former BJP state president Vinay Katiyar, who has been vocal about his views on the alleged Ram temple donation theft, was not seen at the meeting, party sources said.

Katiyar said on Friday said the sanctity of the Ram temple must be upheld irrespective of the ongoing investigation into alleged embezzlement of donations and that the “wrongdoing” was unacceptable. MPOST

BILL TO SACK MINISTERS IN CUSTODY FOR 30 DAYS

Will strongly oppose Bill in Parliament: Cong

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Sunday asserted that it will strongly oppose in Parliament a Constitution amendment Bill which seeks the removal of ministers in custody for 30 days over serious offences, and expressed confidence that the government would not have a two-thirds majority for its passage.

The Opposition party’s assertion comes days after sources said a Parliamentary panel examining Bills to remove the prime minister, chief ministers and other ministers arrested on criminal charges is likely to adopt its report on the proposed legislation on July 17 and submit it in the Lok Sabha in the Monsoon Session.

If the government wishes, the draft legislations could be approved by the Union Cabinet before being introduced in the Monsoon Session of Parliament, which will begin on

Closer Look

» ‘Government would not have a two-thirds majority for its passage’

» Jairam Ramesh claimed that the proposed legislation is aimed at ‘political harassment’ of adversaries

July 20.

Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh claimed that the proposed legislation is aimed at “political harassment” of adversaries.

Ramesh also expressed confidence that Home minister Amit Shah will not be able to muster a two-thirds majority for getting the Constitution amendment Bill that involves delimitation for providing women’s reservation.

“They will try to bring the 130th Constitutional Amendment Bill, which we are going to oppose. It is a dangerous Bill that was introduced in August of 2025 and was subsequently referred to a Joint Parliamen-

tary Committee (IPC), which most Opposition parties boycotted,” Ramesh told news agency.

The Bill states that if a minister is in jail for 30 consecutive days for a criminal offence punishable by more than five years, then on the 31st day, he or she will be dismissed, the Congress leader said.

“This is extraordinary. I mean, court proceedings are still going on. In India, you are presumed innocent until proven guilty. We all know how the probe agencies have been functioning in the (Prime Minister Narendra) Modi-Home minister Amit Shah regime,” Ramesh said.

Referring to the Bill, he said

this is nothing but “political vendetta” and “political vengeance.” “It is to ensure political harassment of your adversaries,” Ramesh added.

“They may try to reintroduce it in this session, during the Monsoon Session... We are going to oppose it, we are going to oppose the delimitation Bill which came during a Special Session on April 16 and the home minister was humiliated beyond measure on April 17 when he got only 298 MPs for the Constitutional amendment on delimitation, whereas he required 352 votes,” Ramesh said.

Since April 17, Shah has been trying to split various political parties, the Congress general secretary alleged.

“He split the TMC and the Shiv Sena (UBT). Yes, those splits are a challenge for us. It is a setback for the Shiv Sena (UBT), it is a setback for the TMC, and it is a setback for the Opposition. But our unity and solidarity continues,” he said.

Cong, BJP and SAD acting together to target Punjab CM Mann: AAP

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHANDIGARH: The ruling AAP in Punjab accused the Congress, BJP and SAD on Sunday of acting together to target Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann, claiming that the Opposition parties have no answer to the state government’s performance.

Addressing a press conference here, Aam Aadmi Party’s (AAP) Punjab media in-charge Baltej Pannu alleged that the three parties have become “Teams A, B and C”, with the sole objective of attacking the Mann government.

Calling the Congress “directionless”, Pannu claimed that the party is preoccupied with internal power struggles.



He also claimed that the Congress and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) are working in coordination in Punjab.

Taking a swipe at the BJP, Pannu said it has become an extension of the Congress in Punjab as many of its present leaders are former members of the grand old party, while the original leadership of the saffron party has been sidelined.

Referring to senior Congress leader Sukhinder Singh Randhawa’s recent meet-

ing with Union Home Minister Amit Shah in New Delhi, Pannu said the political significance of the deliberations is evident despite Randhawa’s explanation.

Highlighting the AAP government’s achievements, Pannu claimed that canal water has reached tail-end villages for the first time in decades and around 90 per cent of households in the state are receiving zero electricity bills due to the scheme providing 600 units of free power.

Pannu further claimed that more than 34 lakh women have started receiving the financial assistance promised by the AAP government, adding that the remaining eligible beneficiaries would receive the benefit from August 1.

LJP (Ram Vilas) ramping up UP push, eyeing Assembly polls: Chirag Paswan

OUR CORRESPONDENT

LUCKNOW: Union Minister and Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) president Chirag Paswan on Sunday said his party will celebrate the birth anniversary of its founder Ram Vilas Paswan in Lucknow this year as part of its efforts to strengthen the organisation in Uttar Pradesh ahead of the Assembly elections.

Addressing reporters, Paswan said the party was working to expand its organisational base across the country while carrying forward the ideals of the late Ram Vilas Paswan.

“The party has decided to celebrate the birth anniversary of our founder, my leader and my father, the late Ram Vilas Paswan, in Lucknow this year.

With this programme, we aim to infuse new energy into the organisation and



Union Minister Chirag Paswan pays tribute to his father Ram Vilas Paswan on the latter’s birth anniversary PTI

strengthen the party in Uttar Pradesh,” he said.

He said the LJP (Ram Vilas) had already established a strong presence in Bihar and had legislators in Jharkhand and Nagaland, while continuing to expand its footprint in several northeastern states.

“With the same vision, we have set a target of strengthening the organisation in Uttar

Pradesh. In the coming days, several programmes will be organised in different districts of the state under the leadership of the state unit,” Paswan said.

On whether the party would contest the Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections and its alliance strategy, Paswan said the party was keen to enter the electoral fray, but decisions on seat-sharing and the alliance would be taken by the state unit and approved by the central parliamentary board.

“I honestly admit that the Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) intends to contest the Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections. The nature of the alliance and the number of seats we will contest will be decided by the state unit, whose proposal will be sent to the central parliamentary board for final approval,” he said.

GOVERNMENT OF MAHARASHTRA
Public Works Department
Executive Engineer, P.W. (North) Division, Dhule-424001
E-TENDER NOTICE NO.6 / 2026-2027
Online Tenders (e-tender) in “B-1” form for the 01 (One) works are invited by the Executive Engineer, P.W. (North) Division, Dhule, (Phone no. 02562-288763) on Government of Maharashtra Electronic Tender Management System. [http:// mahatenders.gov.in](http://mahatenders.gov.in) from any bidder who satisfy the qualifying criteria.
As per above tender notice, 01 (One) works, detail tender information will be available at <http:// mahatenders.gov.in> and can be download from 06/07/2026 at 18:00 hrs. to 13/07/2026 at 17:45 hrs.
Prebid of Above works on 07/07/2026 Time 12.00 Hours in the office of the Cheif Engineer P.W. Region, Nashik
Opening of above works On 15/07/2026 Time 11.00 Hours (If possible) in the office of theSuperintending Engineer, P.W. Circle, Dhule
Executive Engineer, P.W. (North) Division, Dhule
Dgipr/2026-27/1497

GOVERNMENT OF MAHARASHTRA
Public Works Department
Executive Engineer, Public Works Division, Miraj.
Fort area, opp prant office, Miraj 416 410
E-Mail :- miraj.ee@mahapwd.gov.in Phone No. (0233)2222665
PWDM/Tender/ 3235 /2026 Date : 24/06/2026

E- Tender Notice No 03 Year 2026-27 (IInd Call)		
Online Tender (e-tender) in “B-1” form for the following works is invited by the Executive Engineer, P.W. Division Miraj on Government of Maharashtra Electronic Tender Management System. Tender is available online on https://mahatenders.gov.in Executive Engineer Public Works Division, Miraj reserves the right to accept or reject any offer. Conditional tenders will not be accepted.		
Sr. No.	Name of Work	Amt Rs in Lakh
1.	Construction of RCC Compound Wall on all Sides, Construction of Entrance Gate with Guard Room, Repairs to Hostel, BT to Internal Roads. Development of Open Space & Providing Parking Sheds, Construction of Closed shed for Medicines, OPD I floor, OPD 2th floor, OPD ground floor, Nursing Boys Hostel, Nursing Girls Hostel at P.V.P. Government Hospital, Sangli.	1064.54

E-Tender Schedule		
1.	Period of download of Tenders	From :-06/07/2026 to 13/07/2026
2.	Pre-Bid (Online)	Office of the Chief Engineer P.W.Region pune Dt.07/07/2026 at 12.00 Hrs
3.	Place, Time and Date of Bid Opening Date (if possible.)	Executive Engineer, Public Works Division,Miraj Date :- 15/07/2026 at 11.30 Hrs (Online) if possible.
4.	Submssion of Hard Copy (Office Addresses) as on date 15/07/2026 at 11.30 am	Executive Engineer, Public Works Division,Miraj Executive Engineer, Public Works (West) Division, Sangli Superintending Engineer, Public Works Circle, Kolhapur.

All information of e-tendering is available on the following website.
1. <https://mahapwd.com>
2. <https://mahatenders.gov.in>
(If there is any change in the instructions, the information will be communicated on the website)
The tender notice able to see on the Information Panel of the office
Dgipr/2026-27/1482
Executive Engineer, Public Works Division, Miraj

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Imran S/o Kallu R/o Sallu ka makan, Badi Masjid, Mandoli, Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 158/2024 U/s 379/356/411/34 IPC, P.S. GTB Enclave, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Imran** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Imran** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant),

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Imran** of case **FIR No. 158/2024 U/s 379/356/411/34 IPC, P.S. GTB Enclave, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.08.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Sanghmitra
Judicial Magistrate First Class-01
Room No. 54, 2nd Floor, Shahdara District
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No. CC-6/E-Auction/Commercial Publicity/2024 Date:03.07.2026

NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION

Sr Divisional Commercial Manager, North Central Railway, Prayagraj in terms of Railway Board letter dated 13.06.2022 invites various auction bids through E-Auction module in IREPS for following Category / stations / locations of Prayagraj Division.

SN: 1, Details of publicity : Multi Purpose Units on various railway station for the period of 05 years: Prayagraj (02 location)

E-Auction catalogue No.: PRYJ-MPS-26-8

E-Auction Start Date & Time: 08.07.2026 at 11.00 hrs

SN: 2, Details of publicity : Catering Units on various railway station for the period of 05 years: Bharwari (01 location), Sonbhadra(01 location), Manikpur(01 location), Khatwa(01 location), Aligarh(01 location), Mainpuri(01 location)

E-Auction catalogue No.: PRYJ-CATG-26-17

E-Auction Start Date & Time: 08.07.2026 at 11.00 hrs

SN: 3, Details of publicity : Multi Purpose Units on various railway station for the period of 05 years: Prayagraj (01 location)

E-Auction catalogue No.: PRYJ-MPS-26-9

E-Auction Start Date & Time: 14.07.2026 at 11.00 hrs

SN: 4, Details of publicity : Catering Units on various railway station for the period of 05 years: Bharathana(01 location), Meja Road(01 location), Khaga (01 location), Iradatganj(01 location), Dadri (01 location), Khurja(02 location), Khatga(01 location), Chunar (01 location), Naini(01 location)

E-Auction catalogue No.: PRYJ-CATG-26-18

E-Auction Start Date & Time: 14.07.2026 at 11.00 hrs

SN: 5, Details of publicity : Catering Units on various railway station for the period of 05 years: Bharathana(01 location), Sirathu (01 location), Khurja (01 location), Iradatganj(01 location), Sonbhadra(01 location) Prayagraj

E-Auction catalogue No.: PRYJ-CATG-26-19

E-Auction Start Date & Time: 20.07.2026 at 11.00 hrs

SN: 6, Details of publicity : Installation, Maintenance & operation of Travel Help Desk Kiosk for ride hailing services in 6x6 area at Kanpur (02 Locations), Prayagraj (01 Locations) and Govindpuri (01 Locations) Railway Station for a period of Three (03) Years.

E-Auction catalogue No.: MSS-THDPK-03STN

E-Auction Start Date & Time: 10.07.2026 at 10.00 hrs

SN: 7, Details of publicity : Contract for work of up-gradation, maintenance and manning of AC waiting rooms with modern facilities, amenities like multipurpose stalls and Tourist Kiosk at KANPUR CENTRAL JN. Station of Prayagraj Division, North Central Railway.

E-Auction catalogue No.: NFR-ACWR-CNB-26

E-Auction Start Date & Time: 20.07.2026 at 12.00 hrs

Interested bidders may please visit official website for e-auctioning i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for further details and participating in e-Auction.

Important note: 1. Bidders, who wish to participate in the e-auction module should have valid Digital Signing Certificate (DSC) and same may be procured from any of certifying authority of controller of Certifying Authorities (CCA) Government of India, details of same may be obtained from www.cca.gov.in

2. Prospective bidders will be required to get themselves registered online at IREPS(Commercial Auction Module)

3. One time registration fee of Rs. 10,000.00/- and applicable GST(non-refundable) will be required to be paid online by the entity before participating in any commercial auction.

4. For more information, requirement and various aspects regarding this e-Auction, Interested bidders are advised to visit <http://www.ireps.gov.in/epsn/jsp/common/learningcenter.jsp>

5. Earning Money Deposit (EMD): 10% of the total contractual bid value to be deposited online during the auction, EMD of the successful bidder will be retained as Security Deposit.

6. Railway Administration reserves the full and absolute right to these contracts any point of time (or for taking any decision) depending upon the circumstances if any.

7. Railway Administration reserves the full and absolute right to short terminate these contracts any point of time (or for taking any decision) depending upon the continuation/discontinuation of these trains or commencement of new train services. (para pertains to Leasing of SLRs/VP)

8. The successful bidder will also have to pay applicable GST as imposed by Govt. of India from time to time are applicable. Rail administration will not be responsible for this.

1539/26(DG)

North central railways @CPDRNCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

PSBs begin FY27 with strong loan growth but deposits trail

Retail loans remained the key growth engine even as low-cost Current Account & Savings Account (CASA) deposits stayed under pressure

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Public sector banks started the first quarter of FY27 on a strong footing, reporting double-digit growth in advances, but deposit mobilisation seemed to be trailing the jump in loans.

Retail loans remained the key growth engine even as low-cost Current Account & Savings Account (CASA) deposits stayed under pressure.

Provisional business disclosures by nine of the 12 state-owned lenders for the quarter ended June 30, showed loan growth ranging from around 12 per cent to nearly 29 per cent year-on-year compared to deposit growth of 3.5-16 per cent, reflecting sustained credit demand despite a slower pace of liability mobilisation.

Among the major lenders, Bank of Baroda reported a 17.4 per cent year-on-year rise in global advances against a 13.8 per cent increase in deposits, while Bank of India posted 18.64 per cent loan growth and a 14.92 per cent rise in deposits.

Punjab National Bank's (PNB) advances grew 12.85 per cent year-on-year compared



Provisional business disclosures by nine of the 12 state-owned lenders for Q1 FY27, showed loan growth ranging from around 12% to nearly 29% year-on-year against deposit growth of 3.5-16%

to an 8.5 per cent increase in deposits.

Canara Bank reported 18 per cent growth in loans and an 11.7 per cent rise in deposits, while Indian Bank recorded 13.9 per cent loan growth and a 13.3 per cent jump in deposits.

Central Bank of India emerged as the fastest-growing lender in the group, with

advances rising 28.8 per cent year-on-year against an 11.7 per cent expansion in deposits.

UCO Bank reported a 21.3 per cent rise in advances and an 11 per cent increase in deposits, and Punjab & Sind Bank posted 19.5 per cent loan growth and a 12.2 per cent rise in deposits.

Union Bank of India stood

Key Points

- » Among major lenders, Bank of Baroda reported a 17.4% year-on-year rise in global advances against a 13.8% rise in deposits
- » Bank of India posted 18.64% loan growth & 14.92% rise in deposits
- » PNB's advances grew 12.85% against an 8.5% rise in deposits
- » Canara Bank's loans grew 18% against 11.7% rise in deposits, while Indian Bank's loans grew 13.9% against 13.3% rise in deposits

out for relatively weak deposit mobilisation, with the component growing just 3.5 per cent year-on-year, even as advances increased 12.5 per cent.

Retail, agriculture and MSME (RAM) loans continued to drive credit expansion across lenders. Canara Bank reported the highest growth among peers, with domestic

RAM advances rising 21.3 per cent year-on-year, followed by Bank of India at 19.7 per cent and Bank of Baroda at 18.5 per cent. Indian Bank's RAM portfolio grew 14.8 per cent, while Union Bank's expanded 11.56 per cent.

The faster pace of lending compared to deposit growth also resulted in a further rise in credit-deposit ratios at several lenders.

Punjab National Bank's global credit-deposit ratio improved to 73.92 per cent from 71.1 per cent a year earlier, while UCO Bank's ratio rose to 82.15 per cent from 75.38 per cent.

Union Bank's domestic credit-deposit ratio also increased sharply to over 83.38 per cent.

Meanwhile, the pressure on low-cost deposits persisted. Union Bank's CASA ratio declined marginally to 35.10 per cent from 35.51 per cent a year ago, while Central Bank of India's CASA ratio fell to 46.61 per cent from 46.88 per cent.

Indian Bank's domestic CASA ratio also eased to 39.64 per cent from 39.67 per cent at the end of March.

India's middle class to drive 93% of consumption by 2036, says FM

NEW DELHI: India's middle class is set to become an even bigger driver of growth, with 93 per cent of all spending in India expected to come from middle-class and aspirational consumers by 2036, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said at the Rencontres Économiques d'Aix-en-Provence in France on Saturday.

She said the geographic base of this growth is also shifting. Nearly 500 cities are poised to emerge as new centers of economic activity, and unlike in many economies, India's middle class is not concentrated only in Mumbai, Delhi, Bengaluru or Chennai. "They are, on the contrary, in these tier two, tier three cities. So the distribution of wealth is actually automatically seen spreading to cities beyond the metropolitan," she noted.

Sitharaman called the middle class "not just a beneficiary of growth, but actually the engines of growth," pointing to consumption as the trigger for a virtuous cycle of economic activity. Today, 31 per cent of India's population is middle class, and since 1995 the segment has grown at a 6.3 per cent annual rate. As per OECD projections, India will surpass China in absolute middle-class population size between 2030 and 2035.

The Minister outlined how policy has sought to expand the middle class from lower-income groups. The first step was financial inclusion through



Finance Min Nirmala Sitharaman

Sitharaman called the middle class 'not just a beneficiary of growth, but actually the engines of growth'

Jan Dhan accounts, launched in 2014. She cited World Bank and IMF data that 248 million people have moved out of multidimensional poverty, many of whom entered the formal banking system through these accounts. To support entrepreneurship, the government provided sovereign-guaranteed concessional loans so borrowers without collateral could start small businesses. Many have since graduated to larger loans and built credit scores, she said. Digital infrastructure was the second pillar. Payments and banking were made accessible on feature phones and in regional languages, not just smartphones, helping informal businesses formalize and improving creditworthiness.

On taxation and welfare, Sitharaman said the income tax

Highlights

- » 'Nearly 500 cities are poised to emerge as new centers of economic activity'
- » 'And India's middle class is not concentrated only in Mumbai, Delhi, Bengaluru or Chennai'
- » 'They are, on the contrary, in these tier two, tier three cities. So distribution of wealth is actually automatically seen spreading to cities beyond the metropolitan'

exemption limit was raised from Rs 0.25 million to Rs 1.2 million, putting more disposable income in households. The GST was cut across commodities to support consumption and small businesses. In health, every family gets Rs 5 lakh annual insurance cover under a cashless scheme, and citizens' pharmacies provide generic medicines at up to 80 per cent lower cost.

In skills, the government is funding girls' hostels in every district for STEM education and setting up five university townships for training. It is also skilling youth in AVGC — audiovisual, graphics and gaming — to serve India's film, OTT and export markets. "Middle class is supported through these very measures. And they are today, therefore, an engine of India's growth," she said. ANI

SBI to recruit 1,500 probationary officers this year to drive biz growth

NEW DELHI: The country's largest lender State Bank of India (SBI) is planning to recruit 1,500 probationary officers this year to drive its business growth.

Of the total, 1,446 are regular vacancies, and the remaining 54 are backlog vacancies, SBI said in a recruitment notice.

The last date for application is July 8, and the bank expects to complete the entire process by December. As per the eligibility criteria, an applicant should be a graduate in any discipline with a minimum age of 21 years as of April 1, 2026.

Besides, State Bank of India onboards professionals through lateral recruitment from diverse backgrounds, including IT professionals and domain experts, appointed as Specialist Officers across key functions, such as data centres, information technology, risk management, legal, treasury, compliance and data analytics, depending on the evolving and multidisciplinary nature of banking.

Last financial year, SBI hired 67 sportspersons to promote Indian sports and cultivate a team of disciplined, high-performing individuals.

In all, State Bank of India hired 4,640 officers, 19,340 associates, and 1,653 contractual staff in 2025-26, according to the bank's latest annual report. PTI

Mcap of 6 of top-10 most valued companies surges ₹1 lakh crore

NEW DELHI: The combined market valuation of 6 of the top-10 most valued firms surged by Rs 1 lakh crore last week, with Bharti Airtel and Bajaj Finance emerging as the biggest gainers, amid a largely positive trend in equities.

Last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex climbed 663.44 points, or 0.86 per cent, and the NSE Nifty rose 214.85 points, or 0.89 per cent.

Markets ended the week on a firm footing, supported by resilient domestic macro-economic indicators, healthy GST collections and improving industrial activity. Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said,

"Expectations of a more accommodative global monetary policy following softer-than-expected US labour market data further strengthened investor sentiment," he



added.

The market valuation of Bharti Airtel jumped Rs 36,529.21 crore to Rs 11,63,877.30 crore, the most among the top-10 firms.

Bajaj Finance added Rs 33,059.83 crore, taking its valuation to Rs 6,43,141.36 crore.

ICICI Bank's valuation surged Rs 16,084.29 crore to Rs 10,11,695.03 crore, and that of Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) climbed Rs 8,601.99 crore to 5,44,139.55 crore.

The market capitalisation

(mcap) of HDFC Bank rallied Rs 7,664.89 crore to Rs 12,33,646.33 crore, and that of Hindustan Unilever edged higher by Rs 6,461.38 crore to Rs 5,17,086.30 crore.

However, the mcap of Larsen & Toubro tumbled Rs 26,572.2 crore to Rs 5,53,978.63 crore.

The mcap of Reliance Industries eroded by Rs 18,945.56 crore to Rs 17,64,981.36 crore, and that of State Bank of India (SBI) declined by Rs 4,846.08 crore to Rs 9,59,891.92 crore.

The market valuation of Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) dipped by Rs 1,031.15 crore to Rs 7,57,175.27 crore.

Reliance Industries remained the country's most valued firm, followed by HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, ICICI Bank, SBI, TCS, Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro, LIC and Hindustan Unilever. PTI

AI investment in emerging markets must go beyond models to ecosystems, says report

NEW DELHI: Artificial intelligence is moving from experimental tools to a general-purpose technology that could reshape production, productivity and economic growth, but its benefits in emerging markets will depend on building sustainable local ecosystems, not just importing models, according to a new report by World Bank Group.

The report argued that AI is evolving rapidly from traditional pattern-recognition systems, to generative AI that creates content, to emerging agentic AI that can plan and execute multi-step tasks with little human help. Because adoption is spreading faster than previous tech waves, demand is strong worldwide. In emerging markets, AI offers a chance to leapfrog constraints in education, healthcare and finance, where defined tasks and large



data sets exist.

However, development remains highly concentrated in a few high-income economies. For emerging markets to capture value, the authors say investment decisions must look beyond model-centric hype and assess the full operating environment: digital infrastructure, data, skills, and the actors that connect them.

AI-enabling elements include hard infrastructure like connectivity, data centers, high-performance computing and edge devices; soft infrastructure like skills programs,

accelerators, research hubs and AI communities; digital public infrastructure for identity, payments and data exchange; and AI building blocks such as foundational models, MLOps platforms and data tools. The report highlights both proprietary and open-source/open-weight approaches as ways to lower costs and increase local control. AI-enabled elements are vertical AI solutions built for specific sectors. These range from AI-enhanced versions of existing software to AI-native firms built from the ground up, including fintech credit scoring in Africa and agritech yield prediction in South America.

The report outlined three impact horizons. Short to medium term, direct gains from local adoption productivity, cost efficiency, better service delivery.

Medium to long term: bene-

fits from building domestic ecosystems, jobs, skills, exports and stronger institutions. Long term: systemic gains from global diffusion, new industries, occupations and scientific discoveries.

Key challenges flagged include fragmented markets and low purchasing power that complicate monetization, concentration among a few global players, and rapid commoditization of models and infrastructure. The handbook recommends validating product-market fit early, investing in local adaptation, and using open tools where appropriate.

The report said sustainable AI in emerging markets requires coordination across governments, businesses, investors, communities & entrepreneurs. With the right foundations, AI can support long-term economic transformation tailored to local needs & capacities. ANI

Govt says 15 vessels carrying urea, DAP and Sulphur cross Strait of Hormuz safely

NEW DELHI: India's fertilizer supply chain has remained largely unaffected by the recent conflict in West Asia, with 15 of 20 vessels carrying fertilizers and raw materials for the country having safely crossed the Strait of Hormuz, the Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers said on Sunday.

Of these, eight vessels are transporting 3.32 lakh tonne of urea, four vessels are carrying 2.57 lakh tonne of DAP, and three vessels hold 1.11 lakh tonne of Sulphur all on schedule for Indian ports. Five more vessels are in the pipeline, including one each carrying 0.25 lakh tonne of Ammonia and 0.45 lakh tonne of urea.

Loading is currently underway on two additional urea vessels and one Sulphur vessel, the Ministry said in a statement, adding that all shipments are expected to arrive as planned.

While the conflict disrupted maritime traffic through the Strait, the Centre said it had ensured uninterrupted fertilizer availability through "timely planning, effective coordination and continuous monitoring."

New supply sources were also tapped through diplomatic outreach. Urea supplies have been arranged from Oman, Malaysia, Vietnam, Georgia, Nigeria, Russia, Finland, Egypt, Algeria, Turkiye and the Netherlands.

For DAP and NPK, India secured cargoes via the Red Sea route from Russia, Morocco, Egypt, the US, Jordan, South Korea, Tunisia and Saudi Arabia.

Union Minister for Chemicals and Fertilizers JP Nadda said the West Asia conflict had severely disrupted global supply chains, pushing up fertilizer prices and lengthening shipment transit times, with India not spared from the fallout. However, he said the government had kept farmers' interests protected despite the global price surge, crediting the Department of Fertilizers for proactive measures under the Prime Minister's guidance.

Natural gas supply to fertilizer plants 'which had dropped to nearly 65 per cent during the disruption' has now been fully restored to 100 per cent, allowing all urea plants nationwide to operate at full capacity.

Domestic urea production in Q1 FY27 stood at 71.55 lakh tonne against a target of 67.86 lakh tonne 'a beat of 3.69 lakh tonne. DAP output touched 9.84 lakh tonne versus a target of 8.61 lakh tonne, while NPK production came in at 20.77 lakh tonne & SSP at 13.50 lakh tonne.

Against an annual requirement of 383.9 lakh tonnes, India has secured fertiliser stocks of 197.56 lakh tonne' over 51 per cent of the yearly need. PTI

'Crude oil prices, global trends, TCS earnings to drive markets this week'

NEW DELHI: Trading sentiment in the stock market this week will depend on crude oil prices, global trends and the start of corporate earnings season with IT bellwether TCS reporting its June-quarter financial results on July 9, analysts said.

Besides, the advancement of the southwest monsoon and trading activity of foreign investors would also influence market trading, the analysts added.

"Investors will closely monitor the quarterly results of TCS on July 9, with particular focus on management commentary regarding demand trends, discretionary spending, and AI-led business opportunities,"



Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research, Religare Broking Limited, said,

Last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex climbed 663.44 points, or 0.86 per cent, and the NSE Nifty increased by 214.85 points, or 0.89 per cent.

"Domestically, investor attention will centre on the commencement of the Q1 FY27 earnings season from July

9, with the initial batch of corporate earnings and management commentary expected to provide valuable insights into demand conditions, margin trends, and earnings visibility," Praveesh Gour, Senior Technical Analyst at Swastika Investmart Ltd, said.

Additionally, the progress of the southwest monsoon and kharif sowing will remain important indicators for rural demand, inflation expectations, and overall economic growth, he noted.

Meanwhile, the next round of technical talks between the US and Iran is expected to take place on July 11, although a final decision on the venue has yet to be announced. PTI

FMCG firms optimistic on demand outlook, expect easing input costs to support margins

Companies like Dabur India, Godrej Consumer Products Ltd (GCPL) and Marico have reported strong business momentum in the June quarter

NEW DELHI: Leading FMCG makers have expressed optimism on consumption trends, growth prospects, and margin improvement for the current fiscal, even as they continue to monitor inflationary pressures and the potential impact of El Nino-induced weather volatility.

Demand conditions remained resilient, supported by steady economic activity, while easing commodity prices are expected to recover margins progressively in the coming quarters, said fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) companies in their respective

first-quarter business updates.

Companies like Dabur India, Godrej Consumer Products Ltd (GCPL) and Marico have reported strong business momentum in the June quarter and are optimistic over consumption trends for the rest of FY27, despite inflationary pressures, commodity volatility and geopolitical uncertainties.

Marico expects its consolidated revenue to grow in the early twenties, while GCPL expects to achieve high-teens growth. Similarly, Dabur also expects double-digit growth in consolidated revenue and profit after tax for the quarter ended

June 30, 2026.

The markers indicated broad-based growth across domestic and international markets, supported by resilient consumer demand, improving rural sentiment and continued strength in emerging channels, such as e-commerce and quick commerce.

FMCG companies also raised their concerns over elevated input costs and sourcing challenges during the period.

GCPL said input costs remained elevated through most of the April-June quarter, but have started easing in the closing weeks of the period.

CLOSER LOOK

- » Marico expects its consolidated revenue to grow in early 20s, while GCPL expects to achieve high-teens growth
- » Similarly, Dabur also expects double-digit growth in consolidated revenue & profit after tax for Q1 FY27
- » GCPL said input costs remained elevated through most of the April-June quarter, but have started easing in the closing weeks of the period

"On the commodity front, input costs remained elevated through most of Q1, broadly within the cost impact ranges outlined in our previous update. Encouragingly, costs have begun to ease in the closing

weeks of the quarter," said the Godrej Industries Group (GIG) group firm.

The company said it expects margins to recover progressively during the year through calibrated pricing actions, cost-

savings initiatives and media optimisation efforts.

"Our response has been consistent with our established approach to navigating commodity cycles, calibrated pricing actions, strong delivery on cost-savings programmes, and prudent media optimisation, and we expect margins to recover progressively through the year," said GCPL, which owns popular brands such as Good Knight, HIT, Ezee, Cinthol and Godrej No 1.

However, it remains "mindful" that El Nino conditions can heighten "weather volatility across our key markets" with the potential to disrupt agricultural output and rural demand.

GCPL said its geographically diversified sourcing network and portfolio provide resilience against such risks, and it does not foresee any major impact. "With revenue growth tracking ahead of our original expectations and input costs beginning to ease, we enter the remainder of FY27 with increased confidence. We remain firmly on track to deliver our guidance for the full year with the strong likelihood to exceed the same in select metrics," it noted.

According to Dabur, it continues to focus on its strategic priorities aimed at capturing, improving consumption trends, enhancing cost competitiveness, leveraging digital capabilities and delivering sustainable and profitable growth over the medium to long term.

Dabur said overall, the underlying fundamentals of the business remain strong.

It expects consumption in its international markets, which contributes nearly one-fourth of its consolidated revenue, to improve in the coming quarters as the situation in West Asia stabilises. PTI

— KYLIAN MBAPPE SCORES 19TH CAREER WORLD CUP GOAL —
France reach World Cup QFs with 1-0 win over Paraguay

PHILADELPHIA: Kylian Mbappe laughed and smiled — and scored, of course — when Paraguay tried to bait him and his French teammates into fouls and provoke fights, as hot heads became a recurring theme during one of the steamiest World Cup games on record.

After the final whistle, Mbappe kept on walking and left Paraguayan goalkeeper Orlando Gill hanging as Gill extended his right hand in a show of sportsmanship.

In response, Gill threw the ball right at the No. 10 on Mbappe's jersey.

Mbappe got the last laugh as he scored his 19th career World Cup goal, and France survived stifling heat to beat Paraguay 1-0 on Saturday, sending Les Bleus into the quarterfinals for the fourth straight time.

"We knew what kind of match it was going to be," Mbappe said in French. "We can also get our hands dirty, we know how to do it. We know how to play ugly football. Guess they were thinking we were going to show up in tuxedos, but we were ready."

France advanced to play Morocco on Thursday in Foxborough, Massachusetts. France beat Morocco 2-0 in the semifinals of the 2022 World Cup in Qatar.

With an extreme heat warning in effect throughout the match as temperatures hovered around 100 degrees Fahrenheit (38 Celsius), Mbappe finally broke through against a physical, defensive-minded Paraguay side when he converted a penalty kick in the 70th minute.

That was enough for Les Bleus, whose red, white and blue-clad fans looked plenty patriotic on July Fourth in the city where the United States was founded exactly 250 years earlier.

Mbappe was awarded the



France's Kylian Mbappe (10) celebrates his team victory at the end of World Cup football match against Paraguay AP/PTI

The 26-year-old Gill had bested German great Manuel Neuer in a penalty shootout in the previous round

penalty when Diego Gomez was called for tripping after a video review. Then he stuttered on his way to his 19th goal in 19 World Cup appearances, one behind career record holder Lionel Messi of Argentina. Mbappe and Messi each have seven goals in this tournament to top the Golden Boot race.

Mbappe won that award four years ago, but Messi and Argentina beat France in the final. Mbappe — who frequently trash-talked the Paraguayans in Spanish — is now the only player to score at least three goals in the knockout

stage of three World Cups.

Mbappe botched a breakaway attempt in the second half, and Manu Koné had his top-corner shot knocked away by Gill after he was wiped out in the netting by Ousmane Dembélé only moments earlier.

Gill also stopped two strong attempts by Mbappe in second-half stoppage time.

The 26-year-old Gill had bested German great Manuel Neuer in a penalty shootout in the previous round. He then lost his cool after the loss to France when he chucked the ball at Mbappe.

"I tried to shake his hand, but since he didn't pay me any attention, I lost my temper," Gill said. "But anyway, that was all I did; I calmed down afterward."

For the criticism that hydration breaks have watered down the pace of play at the World Cup, they were never more needed for the players than in the midst of a miserable heat wave. Sprinklers showered the Kentucky bluegrass field during the breaks and at halftime.

"Given our style of play, it was harder to give high intensity," France coach Didier Deschamps said.

More than in any of the five other World Cup games played before 68,000-plus fans at Lincoln Financial Field, spectators fled for the concourse at halftime, seeking shade and refuge from the sun.

Maybe they were looking for some action of any kind.

Les Bleus scored 13 goals in the first five games of the tournament but were stymied in the first half by a Paraguay team trying to turn the match into a rock fight. Tempers flared when Andrés Cubas took down Mbappe and the teams briefly pushed and shoved each other. Matias Galarza also threw his right elbow into Mbappe and sent him crashing to the grass.

Paraguay advanced by beating Germany in a penalty shootout on Monday, the biggest upset of this World Cup. But after a gritty effort by La Albirroja, it's France that's moving on.

AGENCIES

Morocco beat WC co-host Canada 3-0; advance to QFs

HOUSTON: Morocco is heading back to the World Cup quarterfinals and coach Mohamed Ouahbi believes his team has established itself among soccer's elite.

Azzedine Ounahi scored twice to lead Morocco to a 3-0 win over Canada in the Round of 16 Saturday to make the country the first African nation to reach the quarterfinals more than once.

"We are no longer a surprise," Ouahbi said through an interpreter. "Now when people talk about Morocco we're a major contender and it's a great source of pride. I think it's only the beginning and I hope we continue to have runs like this."

And despite already making history in this World Cup, Morocco has much higher goals.

"We want to keep going," Ouahbi said. "We don't want to stop."

It's Morocco's second straight appearance in the final eight after becoming the first African team to reach the semifinals in 2022.



Morocco's Redouane Halhal (25) and Canada's Luc de Fougerolles (4) and Morocco's Noussair Mazraoui (3) battle for the ball during the World Cup match AP/PTI

"We are so proud to represent Africa because it's a continent with a lot of talent and Africa deserves to be in the best level in football," goalkeeper Yassine Bounou said.

Neither team was able to break through until Ounahi took a free kick from Achraf Hakimi and made a right-footed shot through traffic from outside the box to the bottom right corner to put

Morocco on top 1-0 in the 50th minute.

Ounahi made it 2-0 on a right-footed shot from the middle of the box off a pass from Brahim Diaz in the 82nd minute. Soufiane Rahimi added a goal in the final minute of stoppage time.

Morocco will meet France, which beat Paraguay later Saturday, on Thursday in Foxborough, Massachusetts. AGENCIES

In historic win for Philippines, Eala stuns Wimbledon champion Swiatek

LONDON: Alexandra Eala didn't have the option of playing on grass courts growing up in the Philippines.

Instead, she used one that also doubled as a basketball court. "There would be the basketball hoops, so I couldn't really step back a lot because then I would hit the basketball hoop," Eala said.

The 21-year-old Eala found Centre Court at Wimbledon a bit more accommodating Saturday when she beat defending champion Iga Swiatek 7-6 (9), 6-2 in the third round at the grass-court major and made some history in the process.

Eala is the first Filipino player, male or female, to reach



Alexandra Eala

the fourth round of a Grand Slam singles tournament.

The left-handed Eala dropped to her knees and rolled onto her back after hitting a forehand winner on her third match point.

"It's incredible to have my countrymen cheering me on and knowing that we're all in

The left-handed Eala dropped to her knees and rolled onto her back after hitting a forehand winner on her third match point

this together," she said in an on-court interview as she looked around at the Philippines flags.

"This goes out to them, this goes out to my family, this goes out to all the little girls with ruffled socks and chubby cheeks. It means the world," said the 29th-seeded Eala, who saved

India A outplay Sri Lanka A by 10 wickets

GALLE: Pacer Gurnoor Brar made a strong case for a Test debut in Sri Lanka next month with a match haul of 10 wickets in India A's resounding win in the second and final unofficial Test here on Sunday.

Courtesy Sai Sudharsan's 168, India A put up a daunting first innings total of 543, giving them a 177-run lead over Sri Lanka A.

The game moved fast on the fourth and concluding day with Brar running through the Sri Lanka A batting unit with a six-wicket haul in the second innings, following his four wickets in the first innings.

The other contender for a spot in the Test team for the two-match series against Sri Lanka from August, Aquib Nabi, paled in Brar's comparison.

The Punjab pacer had impressed on his India debut in the ODI series against Afghanistan last month. AGENCIES

Leisure

Aamir Khan ties knot with Gauri Spratt at Mumbai home

This is the third marriage of the Bollywood's 'Perfectionist' star



OUR CORRESPONDENT

It was raining heavily in Mumbai on Sunday, disrupting normal life, but that didn't stop Bollywood's 'Perfectionist' Aamir Khan from beginning a new chapter of his life with Gauri Spratt. At his Mumbai home on Sunday, the 'Lagaan' actor tied the knot with Gauri, surrounded by family members and close friends.

Aamir, 61 and Gauri, 47, had a registered marriage under the Special Marriage Act at 12:45 pm on Sunday. The '3 Idiots' actor was surrounded by his close family members, including his son Azad (from his second marriage with filmmaker Kiran Rao). Gauri, too, was accompanied by her son.

The 'Dangal' actor had introduced Gauri Spratt to the media in March 2025 and publicly confirmed his relationship during celebrations for his 60th birthday

Both the newlyweds stuck to traditional and elegant looks on the wedding day.

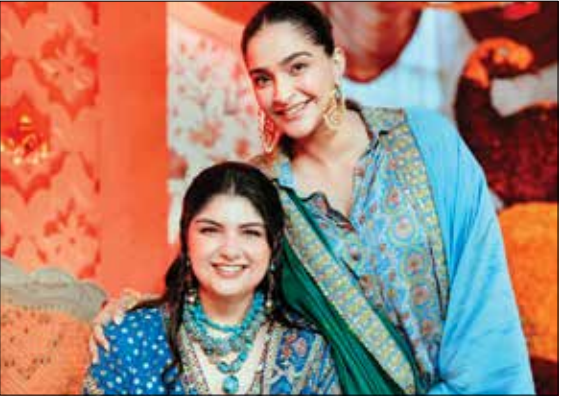
Just a few days ago, at the special screening of Rajkumar Hirani's web series, 'Pritam and Pedro' in Mumbai, the 'PK' actor said that the wedding would be an 'intimate and small affair' only to be attended by close family members and friends. "The wedding is on July 5. We are hosting it at home... It's a very small, intimate affair. It is a very special

day for us. Both families and a few close friends will be there. We just need everyone's blessings for our happiness and pray that we have a wonderful journey ahead," he said.

Meanwhile, politician Raj Thackeray, acclaimed lyricist-writer Prasoon Joshi, businessman Mukesh Ambani, director Ashutosh Gowariker ('Lagaan'), actors Rhea Chakraborty, Vir Das and ex-cricketer Irfan Pathan were seen attending the wedding at Aamir's Bandra residence in Mumbai.

The 'Dangal' actor had introduced Spratt to the media in March 2025 and publicly confirmed his relationship during celebrations for his 60th birthday. Since then, the couple has been spotted several times together. The actor had shared that they have known each other for 25 years but started dating recently. Hailing from Bengaluru, Spratt has a son from her previous relationship. Meanwhile, this is the third marriage of Aamir. He has been married to Reena Dutta and has two kids, Junaid and Ira, with her. Later in 2005, Khan married filmmaker Kiran Rao. In 2021, they announced their separation. However, the couple continue to co-parent their son, Azad.

ANSHULA KAPOOR'S MEHENDI MOMENTS



Bollywood producer Boney Kapoor's daughter, Anshula Kapoor, is getting married to her longtime partner, Rohan Thakkar, on July 6. This event brought the entire Kapoor clan together when the bride-to-be celebrated her mehendi recently with the family.

Anshula and Arjun Kapoor are Boney Kapoor's children from his first marriage. Meanwhile, actors Janhvi and Khushi planned everything for their sister's mehendi.

For the ceremony, Anshula wore a striking teal-blue lehenga by Arpita Mehta, inspired by Gujarat's rich Patola textile heritage. The mehendi ceremony was attended by Arjun Kapoor, Varun Dhawan, Harsh Vardhan Kapoor, Sonam Kapoor, Janhvi, Khushi and the entire Kapoor family.

CELINA JAITLY TO PLAY SISTER NIBEDITA



After directing the Bengali film 'Binodiini: Ekti Natir Upakhyan' on the life of Binodini Dasi, a legendary figure in Bengali theatre, director Ram Kamal Mukherjee has now announced his next Hindi feature. This, too, is a biopic and the director has decided to bring the story and life of Sister Nibedita to the big screen. Produced by 'Aritra Das Creation' in association with 'Assorted Motion Pictures', the film will chronicle the remarkable journey of Sister Nibedita, the Irish-born disciple of Swami Vivekananda who dedicated her life to the service of India. Bollywood actress Celina Jaitly will play the titular role. The film is planned as an ambitious international production and will be extensively shot across Mumbai, Kolkata and Ireland.



SVAMITVA

Transforming Rural Property Rights

Building on the success of the SVAMITVA Scheme, Madhya Pradesh's Ownership Rights Records Execution and Registration Scheme-2026 converts secure land ownership into a powerful engine for financial inclusion, rural prosperity and citizen empowerment



For generations, land has remained the most valuable asset for millions of rural families across India. It provides shelter, sustains livelihoods, supports agriculture and serves as an enduring source of social and economic security. Yet, despite its importance, clear and legally recognised ownership has often remained beyond the reach of many rural citizens. Ambiguous records, incomplete documentation and procedural hurdles have prevented countless families from fully realising the economic value of their property.

Madhya Pradesh is now addressing this longstanding challenge through the Ownership Rights Records Execution and Registration Scheme-2026, a landmark initiative designed to provide legally recognised ownership rights to eligible rural property holders. Building upon the success of the SVAMITVA Scheme, the state has approved a comprehensive framework that transforms surveyed properties into legally enforceable ownership records, ensuring greater certainty, transparency and financial security for rural citizens.

Under the leadership of Chief Minister Dr. Mohan Yadav, the government has adopted a citizen-centric approach that removes traditional barriers to property registration while strengthening rural governance. By simplifying procedures and eliminating financial obstacles, the initiative seeks to ensure that every eligible beneficiary can secure legal ownership without additional burden, making the process more inclusive and accessible.

FROM DOCUMENTATION TO EMPOWERMENT

The initiative represents far more than an administrative exercise. It marks a transition from simple land documentation to genuine citizen empowerment. Secure ownership rights provide rural families with confidence in their assets, reduce uncertainty and create a stronger foundation for long-term economic planning.

The programme builds upon the extensive work undertaken under the SVAMITVA Scheme, through which villages across Madhya Pradesh have been surveyed using advanced drone technology and digital mapping. These surveys have created an accurate and transparent database of rural properties, replacing outdated and often disputed records with scientifically verified information.

The creation of authenticated ownership records reduces ambiguity over property boundaries and ownership status. Families receive greater legal protection over their assets, while local administrations benefit from more reliable land records that simplify governance and improve service delivery. By reducing disputes and strengthening legal certainty, the initiative creates a more secure environment for investment and development in rural areas.

UNLOCKING ECONOMIC OPPORTUNITIES

Perhaps the most transformative aspect of the scheme lies in its ability to convert land ownership into



NO COST TO CITIZENS

One of the most significant features of the Ownership Rights Records Execution and Registration Scheme-2026 is its commitment to ensuring that eligible rural citizens receive legally recognised ownership rights without bearing any financial burden.

In a landmark decision, the Government of Madhya Pradesh has completely waived stamp duty and registration fees for ownership rights records issued under the scheme. Beneficiaries will not be required to pay any charges while obtaining authenticated ownership documents.

Traditionally, property

registration often involved expenses that discouraged citizens from completing the legal process. By removing these costs entirely, the government has ensured that financial limitations do not become obstacles to securing legal ownership.

The state itself will bear the implementation expenditure, estimated at approximately ₹3,800 crore, reflecting a significant investment in rural welfare and inclusive development.

This decision underlines the government's commitment to ensuring that every eligible rural property holder becomes part of the formal ownership framework without financial hardship.

system, villages can experience greater investment, improved infrastructure and sustainable economic growth.

TECHNOLOGY-DRIVEN LAND GOVERNANCE

Technology forms the backbone of Madhya Pradesh's approach to modern land governance.

Advanced drone surveys and high-resolution aerial mapping have been undertaken across all 55 districts of the state, creating accurate digital records of rural properties. These surveys provide scientifically verified information regarding property boundaries and ownership, significantly reducing the scope for future disputes.

Traditional land administration often faced challenges arising from unclear boundaries, outdated records and overlapping claims. Through digital mapping, every surveyed property can now be identified with far greater precision. The resulting records are easier to verify, update and maintain, ensuring long-term transparency within the land administration system.

Digitally authenticated records also improve governance. Property-related services become faster, record management becomes more efficient and administrative processes become increasingly transparent. Citizens gain stronger legal protection, while government departments benefit from a modern and reliable database capable of supporting future planning and service delivery.

The use of technology reflects Madhya Pradesh's broader commitment to transparent, efficient and technology-enabled governance, demonstrating how innovation can improve public administration while strengthening citizen trust.

LEADING THE NATION IN SVAMITVA

Madhya Pradesh has emerged as one of the country's leading performers in implementing the SVAMITVA Scheme. Drone surveys have been successfully completed across all 55 districts, and nearly 98 per cent implementation has been achieved across surveyed villages,

“India's heart lies in its villages, and the development of villages is integral to the nation's progress. The Swamitva Yojana and land reforms will serve as the foundation pillars for rural development. The Swamitva Yojana is a significant step towards realizing the vision of Gram Swaraj (village self-governance) as envisioned by Mahatma Gandhi.

NARENDRA MODI, PRIME MINISTER



placing the state among the national leaders in rural land governance.

The newly approved execution and registration framework represents the next stage of this journey. Survey and mapping efforts are now being translated into legally enforceable ownership rights, ensuring that the benefits of technological innovation reach citizens in practical and meaningful ways.

The state's progress demonstrates that land reforms can become a powerful driver of rural transformation when supported by modern technology, transparent administration and citizen-focused policy.

MISSION-MODE IMPLEMENTATION

To ensure that every eligible beneficiary receives ownership rights records within a defined timeframe, the government has adopted a mission-mode implementation strategy.

A dedicated statewide campaign will be undertaken to complete the remaining stages of execution and registration. Simplified procedures, citizen-friendly service delivery and last-mile administrative outreach will ensure that the benefits of the scheme reach even the most remote rural communities.

Time-bound implementation remains a central objective of the programme. Government departments will work in close coordination to accelerate registration, improve efficiency and minimise procedural delays.

The initiative aims not merely to distribute documents but to establish a comprehensive ownership framework that strengthens legal certainty across rural Madhya Pradesh.

STRONG MONITORING AND COORDINATION

Effective implementation requires continuous monitoring and institutional coordination.

A high-level committee has been constituted to guide implementation, periodically review progress and ensure seamless coordination among all concerned departments. The committee will oversee policy implementation, operational guidelines, inter-departmental coordination, monitoring and evaluation to ensure that the programme achieves its intended objectives.

Regular reviews and performance assessments will help identify implementation challenges while ensuring timely corrective measures wherever required. This institutional framework strengthens accountability and supports efficient delivery of services across the state.

AWARENESS AND CITIZEN OUTREACH

The success of any public initiative depends upon informed citizen participation.

Accordingly, Madhya Pradesh will undertake a dedicated awareness campaign to ensure that eligible beneficiaries understand both the advantages of ownership rights and the procedures for registration.

The campaign will include village-level outreach programmes, public information initiatives, awareness materials, publications and citizen guidance services. Local-level engagement will help ensure that rural families are fully informed about the scheme and are able to complete the registration process without unnecessary difficulty.

This emphasis on awareness reflects the government's commitment to making land governance not only transparent but also participatory and accessible.

BUILDING A STRONGER RURAL FUTURE

The Ownership Rights Records Execution and Registration Scheme-2026 represents much more than a land records initiative. It is a

comprehensive programme aimed at strengthening rural governance, expanding financial inclusion and empowering citizens through secure property ownership. By combining modern technology with transparent administration, legally recognised ownership rights and citizen-centric

implementation, Madhya Pradesh is creating a governance model that addresses longstanding challenges while unlocking new opportunities for rural development.

Secure ownership enables families to invest with confidence, access institutional finance more easily and participate more actively in the formal economy. At the same time, digitally authenticated land records strengthen governance, reduce disputes and improve administrative efficiency.

As rural citizens gain stronger legal protection over their assets, villages become better positioned to support entrepreneurship, agricultural investment, housing development and sustainable economic growth.

Through this transformative initiative, Madhya Pradesh is setting a new benchmark in land governance. By turning property ownership into a pathway for financial inclusion, legal security and economic opportunity, the state is laying the foundation for a stronger, more prosperous and more empowered rural future.

SECURE OWNERSHIP IS MORE THAN A LEGAL DOCUMENT—IT IS THE *foundation* FOR FINANCIAL INCLUSION, ECONOMIC EMPOWERMENT AND SUSTAINABLE RURAL DEVELOPMENT

